

VIVIANNE DOS SANTOS

The Bolt

a novel

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The Bolt

a novel of Véspera



VIVIANNE DOS SANTOS

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

This is a work of fiction. Véspera, its houses and its people are imagined, and any resemblance to real persons is the resemblance true stories bear to one another.

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FROM THE REGISTER OF VÉSPERA

From the register of Véspera

In the register of the village, by the hand of the Keepers who passed through the book, is found:

Dores, daughter of Véspera folk, widow of Aniceto, mother of Joaquim. She spent her life saving those who were sinking: first the husband, who drank, then the son, who inherited from his father the thirst and the shadow. She covered, excused, paid, always placed herself between her own and the harm, and held the house alone at the cost of wearing herself away, because she had learned, as a girl, that to love was that, was to save.

Her name was a promise, of the Véspera kind, of the old and hard ones: her mother wanted her the name of the sorrows, in the hope of a daughter with a back to bear them. And life gave a woman who bore the sorrows of everyone and never her own, until the night when she had to choose between her son and herself, and found herself before the hardest thing a mother can look upon.

The register says who was born, who married whom, who departed. It does not say what it costs a mother to set a limit to a son she loves, nor what is carried from a life of saving one who will not let themselves be saved, nor whether there is, from the depth of so much sheltering, a door that may still

*be shut to the harm without being shut to the one who brings it. For that,
books such as this one are needed.*

CHAPTER ONE

The doorbell



There was a time, in Dore's house, when the doorbell was a joy, because it announced whoever arrived, a neighbour, a piece of news, the children coming in from the street; and there was another time, that of this story, when the doorbell became the thing Dore most feared in the world, because it rang almost only to announce her son, and her son came almost only to ask, and sometimes he came in a way that left her afraid in her own house.

There is a sound that the mothers of these houses learn to dread, and it is the sound of the doorbell at the wrong hour, and Dore had learned it as one learns a language, by repetition and by pain. The doorbell, which for the rest of the world is a neutral sound, a simple announcement that someone has arrived, had become for Dore a laden sound, a sound that set her heart rac-

ing even before she knew who it was, because her body had learned to associate the doorbell with her son and her son with distress. And there was a sadness in this, that of a common sound having become, for her, a sound of fear; that of a thing as banal as a doorbell having been poisoned for her by life, transformed from a neutral announcement into a threat. Does envied, without saying so, the houses where the doorbell was still only a doorbell, a joyful sound of visitors, and she measured, by that envy, how much her life had twisted, to the point that the most common sound of a house had become, in hers, the sound of what she most feared.

Dores had learned to know Quim's ring. There was the daytime ring, more or less normal, which even so tightened her chest because she knew he came to ask; and there was the night ring, insistent, repeated, the finger on the button without letting go, and that ring Does knew well, and on hearing it her whole body froze, because the night ring was Quim's ring when he drank, and Quim when he drank was another, was a man who frightened her, who was not the boy she had raised nor the son she loved, was the drink with her son's face, and Does, on the other side of the door, was left with her heart leaping, not knowing whether to open, whether not to open, whether she should,

whether she could, caught between the mother's love that always wants to open to the son and the woman's fear that had learned to dread that ring.

There was a time, and Does clung to that memory as to a proof that it had not always been so, when Quim was a good boy, her boy, laughing, full of future, a lad like the others, with dreams, with a knack for some things, with a life ahead. Does kept that Quim in her heart, the Quim of before, and it was in part because of him that she could not shut the door to the Quim of now, because she saw in the sunken man the boy he had been, and a mother who sees the boy within the man cannot treat the man as a stranger, however much the man frightens her. And there was a particular pain in this, that of weeping for a son who was alive, that of longing for a boy who had become that man, that of loving at the same time what Quim had been and what Quim was, and of not knowing how to save one without letting herself be destroyed by the other.

Because Quim, Does's son, had inherited from his father the thirst, and with the thirst the shadow. He was a grown man, of the age to make his life, and he made it badly, sunk in the drink as his father had sunk, and his life was a coming-apart slowly

that Does watched from outside, powerless, as one watches a boat sink from the bank. And in that coming-apart, Quim appeared at his mother's house, and he appeared almost always for the same reason: to ask. Money, above all. He came with a story, always a story, a debt, a strait, a promise that it was the last time, and Does heard the story, which she already knew by heart because it was always the same with the names changed, and gave, gave what she had and what she did not have, because he was her son, because she did not know how to send him away empty-handed, because a part of her still believed, against all evidence, that this time the money would get him out of it, that this time it really was the last.

Quim's stories were always good, it must be said, they were stories that touched exactly where they had to touch, because Quim, even in the shadow of the drink, knew his mother better than anyone and knew which keys to press. Once it was a debt to dangerous people, who could bring him serious trouble if he did not pay; another it was a job he would get if he had something to present himself with; another it was his health, a problem, a doctor, a medicine. The stories changed, but they all had the same shape: an emergency, an imminent disaster that only the mother's money could prevent, and a promise that it was the

last time, that with this one he would straighten out. And Does, who had already heard those stories dozens of times, who knew by heart that they were stories, believed all the same, or pretended to believe, because she wanted to believe, because a mother wants to believe her son, because it was easier to give believing than to give knowing it was a lie. And Quim knew this, knew that his mother wanted to believe, and gave her stories she could believe in, and so the two of them kept up, without saying so, a kind of pact: he pretended it was the last time, she pretended she believed, and the money changed hands, and the drinking went on, and the pact repeated itself at the next visit, the same, with a new story.

It was never the last. The money Does gave her son got him out of nothing; it sank him a little more, because it went to the drink, or to plug a hole the drink had opened, and at bottom Does knew it, knew that she was throwing money into a bottomless well, feeding the very thing that destroyed her son. But to know did not make her stop, because between the knowing of the head and the not-managing of a mother's heart there is an abyss, and Does lived in that abyss, giving what she knew did

harm, unable not to give, because not to give seemed to her to abandon her son, and to abandon her son was the only thing she had, in her whole life, never learned to do.

The neighbours saw Quim come in and out of his mother's house, and murmured, because in a village everything is known, and there were those who censured Dores, oh Dores who does not bring that son into line, she always gives in to him, does his bidding, no wonder; and there were those who pitied her, oh Dores, poor thing, what that son puts her through. And Dores felt both things, the censure and the pity, and both wounded her, because the censure was unjust — it was not lack of sense, it was a deep strait that no one from outside had any idea of — and the pity humiliated her, she who had always been the strong one, the one who held on, the one who helped others, to see herself now the object of the village's pity because of a son. But Dores endured both, the censure and the pity, as she endured everything, in silence, with her head high in the street and undone at home, because to expose what was happening, to complain, to ask for help, was a thing she did not know how to do, that she had never learned, and so she carried alone a weight that crushed her, without letting anyone see its size.

The good days, when there were any, were almost worse than the bad ones, for the hope they brought. When Quim appeared sober, with a remnant of the boy he had been, and promised, with a sincere air, that he was going to change, that he was going to get treatment, that this time it was in earnest, Does filled with a hope that hurt her from being so great, and she believed, because she wanted to believe, because a mother clings to any thread of hope like a drowning person to a plank. And then the hope came apart, because the promise was not kept, and Does fell from the hope to the ground, and each one of those falls was a renewed pain, perhaps the worst of all, because hope repeatedly undone wears one out more than constant despair. Does had learned, with time, to distrust her son's promises, not to let herself climb too high so as not to fall from so high; but she never managed to distrust entirely, because to distrust entirely would be to give up, and she did not give up, and so she went on climbing a little in hope at each promise, and falling at each break, in an up and down that wore her out more than any straight line of misfortune.

The drink, it must be said with care and with truth, had not made of Quim a monster; it had made of him a sick man, and that is a different thing. There were days when Quim appeared

sober, and on those days he was still, beneath the harm, the boy Does had raised, with a remnant of tenderness, of shame even at what he had become, and those days broke Does's heart more than the others, because they showed her the son who was still there, buried, the son who perhaps could be saved if there were a way. And it was because of those days, of the flashes of the healthy son beneath the sick son, that Does could not give up, because she saw that the son was still there, and a mother who sees the son still there within the harm cannot treat the harm as though it were the whole son. The illness and the son lived together in the same man, and Does loved the son and feared the illness, and the drama was that the two came in the same body, at the same door, in the same ring of the bell, and she had to learn, and did not yet know, to open the door to one and shut it to the other.

The house, which had been a home, had become a place of fear and of waiting. Does lived attentive to the doorbell, attentive to the telephone, attentive to news of her son, in a permanent start, and the start ate her, took her sleep, her appetite, her peace. She had grown thin, Does, went about with the air of one who carries a weight that is not seen, and the neighbours noticed, oh Does, poor thing, with that son, that son is wearing her down,

and they were right, the son was wearing her down, but not in the way they thought, not out of malice in the son, but out of a thing deeper and sadder: the son was wearing her down because she let him, because she carried the son on her back, because she had made of her son's salvation her cross, and a cross like that, carried for years on end, crushes the one who carries it.

Dores's days organised themselves, without her wishing it, around her son and the fear of him. In the morning, she woke already with the son in her head, asking herself whether he would come, whether he was well, in what state he was. In the afternoon, she lived attentive, started at any ring, any step in the street, any noise that might be him. At night, it was the worst, because the night was the hour of the dreaded ring, and Dores lay down without resting, with her ear listening, and slept badly, with a light sleep that anything broke. Her whole life turned around Quim, the fear of Quim, the wait for Quim, and nothing was left her for herself, not a thought, not an hour, not a rest, because the son occupied her whole head, from morning to night, present when he came and present when he did not come, because his absence was as occupying as his presence, made of waiting and of fear. And so Dores had no life, she had only the son, she had only the fear and the wait and the distress

of a son who was sinking, and it was a non-life, an existing suspended around another, that consumed her without giving her anything in return but more fear.

And the most terrible is that Does no longer recognised her own house. The house that she and Aniceto had made, where she had raised the children, was now a place where she was afraid at night, where she locked up the things of value, where she hid the little money she had so that the son would not take it, where she lived on alert as one lives in a dangerous place. Her house, her refuge, had become the stage of her fear, and that, for a woman who had made of the house and the family her whole life, was a dull and permanent pain, that of having lost, without leaving it, her own home, transformed by her son's illness into a place of dread.

She had grown thin, Does, and aged quickly in those years, because fear and distress wear out a body faster than work. She went about with a tired air, of one who does not sleep, of one who carries a weight, and her clothes began to hang loose on her, and the neighbours noticed, and she made excuses with the age, with the heat, with whatever it was, so as not to have to tell the truth, which was that it was her son eating her from within.

She had ceased to care for herself, Does, because all her attention and all her money went to her son, and a woman who puts everything into her son ceases to put into herself, ceases to buy what she needs, ceases to make herself up, ceases to care for herself, and Does had done that, had gone on neglecting herself to care for her son, and her own body, neglected, went on wearing away, as everything wears away that is neglected. And there was a sadness in seeing her, Does, a woman who had been strong and dignified reduced to a tired and thin shadow, worn not by the age but by the distress, and the village saw it, and pitied her, and the pity, once more, humiliated her, because she did not want anyone's pity, she wanted only, at bottom, what she had never asked for: that someone help her carry, or rather, that someone tell her that she could lay it down.

But Does did not complain, or complained little, because she had learned, as a girl, not to complain, to endure, to make herself the strong one, the one who holds everything so that others do not see. And she went on opening the door to her son, and giving, and covering, and saving, night after night, request after request, without seeing that she was sinking with him, without hearing, in the sleeping village outside, the voice the story was going to bring her, slowly, and that would tell her what no one

had told her: that to save a son who destroys himself at the cost of destroying oneself saves neither of the two, and that there is a door that, shut in time, is more love than all the doors she had opened.

CHAPTER TWO

The husband who drank



To understand Does one must go back to the husband, to Aniceto, because the son she now saved was the second time Does made that crossing, and the first she had made with his father.

There was, in the chest of drawers in the bedroom, inside a sewing box lined with a cloth long since drained of colour, a small portrait from when they married, and Does still took it out from there, now and then, in the afternoon, alone, and what she saw in the portrait was not the Aniceto of the drink, it was the other one, the one from before, the one from the day he made her laugh at the chapel door to the point that the priest had to cough to call them to order. Because there had been that Aniceto, and Does kept him as she kept the boy Quim, beneath all the bad years, and it was that Aniceto she had loved, a man

with charm, with a way of resting his arm on the windowsill and saying to her come and see this, woman, it's already gone for me but for you it may still come, over nothing, over a swallow, over a cloud with the shape of a thing. And perhaps it was for having loved that man beneath the drink that Dores endured what she endured, because a woman does not endure years on end a man who drinks if she has not loved, beneath, the man he was; she endures out of the hope, always put off and always renewed, that the drink will let go of him and return him to her, and that hope, in Aniceto's case, was what bound her as, afterward, it bound her to Quim.

Aniceto had drunk since before they married, and Dores, young, had thought it a thing of a young man, that it would settle with the house, with the children. She remembered a night, in the early times, when he came home late and she waited for him at the window, and when he came in, with that walk, and made his excuses with his companions, with the cold, with the road, Dores said nothing, made him his supper, and that was the first time of a whole life of suppers made at the wrong hours, though she did not then know that it was the first of so many. The next day she went to the shop, and Benvinda, who was young like her, and who did not yet have the ledger of debts under the

counter but already had the eye, lowered her voice and said to her, without Dores having asked her anything, Dores, your man stayed at Lúcio's last night till closing. And Dores, who was meant to keep quiet, answered what she would answer her whole life: he's tired, Benvinda, it's the work. And Benvinda looked at her over the bread she was setting out, and said no more, but Dores carried that look home, and it was the first time she covered for her husband in front of someone, and she did it without thinking, because she already carried from girlhood that her place was that, to put herself between her own and the shame.

And she went on covering. She excused Aniceto to the family, to the neighbours, to the boss of the sawmill when he missed work on a Monday morning, and it was she who went, in her apron, to tell Senhor Firmino that Aniceto had woken with a fever, and Senhor Firmino, who knew, pretended to believe, out of respect for her, and Dores saw in the man's pretending that he knew, and blushed, and went off quickly. She erased the harm, paid the debts the drink opened, and kept the house standing and the children fed at the cost of what she saved where she could, and she did all this in silence, because to complain was to expose her

husband, and to expose her husband was to fail in the duty to protect him, and Dores had been raised to protect, not to expose.

And above all she protected the children. Her greatest effort, in Aniceto's years, was that they would not see, or would see as little as possible. She sent them to bed early, on the nights when the air carried the foreboding, and told them stories on the stairs so that they would not hear the key missing the lock down below; she set the table in the morning as though nothing were the matter, with the bread cut and the milk steaming, and on the worst mornings she sang, softly, some little song, to fill the kitchen with a thing that was not the laden silence. She thought she protected them so. And she did, in part; but she did not see, then, what she would only understand much later: that the children saw all the same, that children always see, and that what they learned, in watching their mother cover for and save their father a whole lifetime, was the lesson that would lose Quim, that in a house someone drinks and someone saves, and that that is how things are.

She remembered one morning, in particular, that stayed with her and that only now, with the story working on her, she understood. Quim would have been seven or eight, and Aniceto had come home in the middle of the night in a bad way, and tripped on the dish bucket, and made a noise, and in the morning there was a broken chair in the corner of the kitchen. And Dore, before the children came down, leaned the broken chair against the wall, in such a way as to make it look whole, and when Quim came down and looked at the chair, Dore said, quickly, don't lean on that one, it's wobbly, son, and Quim looked at the chair and looked at his mother, and Dore saw, in the boy's eyes, that he had heard everything in the night, and that he knew the chair did not wobble, it had broken; and that he was learning, right there, at seven or eight years old, to look at a broken chair and call it a wobbly chair. It was so, without words, that the son learned the trade of covering up, and Dore taught it to him in the pretence of protecting him.

The children were two, Quim and Glória, and it is revealing how they drew opposite lessons from the same house. Glória was the elder, and was the first to help her mother in the pretending; Quim was the little one, and was the one who kept the father most within him. There was an afternoon, years later, Glória

married now and living far away, when she came to spend a few days, and the two of them were folding sheets in the kitchen, and Glória, out of nowhere, with the sheet stretched between the two of them, said: Mother, do you know what I most want to tell you and never have? That I fled Véspera not because of my father. It was because of you. It was so as not to be you. And Dores was left with the sheet in her hands, and Glória went on, with her voice trembling a little but firm, I watched you save him, Mother, every night, and I swore to myself that I would never marry a man who needed saving, because I did not want your life. And Quim stayed, Mother. Quim stayed and wanted my father's life. We both drew lessons from this house, he and I, and they were opposite. And Dores folded the sheet to the end, slowly, without answering, because there was no answer, and because the daughter had said, in three sentences, at the edge of an unmade bed, what the village had taken thirty years not to say.

What Dores never forgave herself was not having managed to save Aniceto. She tried everything, gave everything, and he died all the same, and Dores was left, afterward, with a dull guilt, that of not having been able, of not having done enough. And it was perhaps that guilt that made her throw herself with such force

into the saving of her son, as though she wanted, in Quim, to achieve what she had failed in the husband, as though the salvation of one could redeem the defeat with the other. But it was a trap, and Does would only see it much later.

Aniceto died of it, in the end, as those die who drink without stopping, slowly and then suddenly. Does cared for him until the last day, and on the eve of his death, when he could barely speak, he asked her for water, and she gave it to him by the spoon, and he gripped her wrist with a strength he should no longer have had and said to her a thing Does kept and never told anyone: you saved me my whole life, Does, and look what it served me for. You should have let me fall once, to see if I learned to get up. And he shut his eyes, and Does was left with the spoon in her hand, and did not understand, then, what the man had said to her; she thought it was the fever speaking, or the repentance, and only years later, with the son on the other side of a shut door, did that sentence come back to her whole, said to the spoon, by a dying man who had seen, before her, what she did not yet want to see.

When he died, Does wept for him with a tired love, and felt, beneath the pain, a thing she was ashamed of: a relief, that of one who lays down a weight they have carried too many years. And she thought, naively, that her crossing was over, that she had borne her cross. There was, between Aniceto's death and Quim's sinking, an interval, a few years of rest, and Does recalled them now as the only time of her adult life in which she had not had to save anyone. And it disquieted her, in recalling them, a thing: that even in that time she had not quite known what to do with herself. Accustomed to a life of saving, when there was no one to save, she felt herself, strange as it seems, a little lost. She remembered a neighbour, Aurora, who lived at the bottom of the street and who had been left lame from a fall, and how Does had offered to do her shopping and scrub her house, and how Aurora, after a few months, had said to her half-laughing, oh Does, I manage now, woman, let me manage, for you seem more distressed that I don't need you than that I'm lame. And Does had laughed too, but she carried that home, because Aurora had touched, without malice, on the bone of the thing: that she needed to be needed, that the emptiness of having no one to shelter left her without ground. Not that she wanted her son to sink, of course not; but when he sank, the part of her

trained to save found its function again, and gave itself to it with a readiness that came not only from love but from that old hunger to have someone to save, to be again the indispensable one.

It is hard to say when Quim's sinking began, because these things begin slowly, without a date. There were a few years when he drank as many drink; then a few when he drank too much, and the family said it would settle; and when it was understood that it did not settle, it already came from far, it was already installed. Does watched it arrive with her heart tightening, because she recognised the signs, she had seen them in her husband. She remembered the exact afternoon when she understood that it was the same: Quim had come to dinner, he still lived with her in those days, and in the middle of the dinner he went to the pantry, and Does heard, from the kitchen, a sound she knew by heart, the sound of a bottleneck striking a glass in a hurried way, in secret, and she went to the pantry and found her son with his back to her, and he turned too quickly, with the glass already empty and the air of one who was doing nothing, and said, I came to see if there was bread, Mother, and Does looked at the shelf where the bread was not and where the bottle was, and it was the first time she saw, in her son, the father's

gesture, the drinking in secret in the pantry, and it was in the son's pantry that the second sinking began, for her, in the same place, in the same house, with the same sound.

And Dorez began again, without even deciding, because it was what she knew how to do. When Quim began to sink, she did with him what she had done with the father: covered, excused, paid, saved. It was automatic, it was the furrow of a lifetime. And Glória, who was far away and saw little, when she came and saw, scolded her mother, and scolded her in that way of hers of touching the depths without raising her voice. She came one time, and the mother, in front of her, gave money to Quim, who had appeared with a story, and when Quim went out Glória stood still in the middle of the kitchen and said only, softly, you have just paid my brother for this week's drink, Mother, and you call that love. And Dorez defended herself, he is your brother, Glória, and Glória answered, I know he is my brother, Mother, what I do not know is whether I still have a mother or only a woman drowning to save him, because every time I come here you are thinner and he is the same. And she went away earlier than she had meant to stay, and Dorez was left watching the car go down the street, and understood, with a dull pain, that each time she threw herself into the water after Quim she was losing

Glória in another way, the daughter who had got free and who could not bear to see her mother sink. And only much later would Doresee see that, in shutting the door to Quim, she would also recover Glória.

At the beginning, with Quim as before with Aniceto, there was only the love and the duty, and Doresee gave herself to saving her son with the same devotion with which she had given herself to saving her husband, without seeing that she was entering, for the second time in her life, the same river that had nearly drowned her the first, and that this time, older, more worn, with less strength, the river might carry her off for good. It was the hands that knew, and her hands, like those of all the women of those houses, went to the pantry before the head commanded. But that was for the end, and the end still came far off, and for now the doorbell rang, and Doresee opened, and gave, and made the supper at the wrong hours, now for the son, as before for his father, in the same corner of the same kitchen, awaiting a return that with Aniceto had never come and that she swore, against all evidence, with Quim would still come.

CHAPTER THREE

What I learned as a girl



There are those who call these people the ones who forget themselves, and Does was one of them, of those who live so turned toward others that they lose sight of themselves, of those who, asked what they want, do not know how to answer, because it is so long since they have asked themselves what they want that the question sounds to them in a foreign language. And it is not for being saints, though they seem it; it is for an old wound, that of one who learned that they had no right to want, to need, to weigh, and who made themselves, for that, wholly at the service of others, because at the service of others they had a place and in wanting for themselves they had none. Does had learned this so early, and so deep, that she no longer knew she had learned it; she took for her nature what was her wound, and lived at the service of others con-

vinced that it was how it ought to be, that that was her way of being good. And it took life nearly killing her, it took the bottom of her son and the night of fear, for Dore's to begin to suspect that that way of hers of being good, that living oneself at the service of others, was not only goodness, it was also a wound, and that perhaps to be truly good included, also, not forgetting oneself.

The role of saviour was not born in Dore's with her husband; it was born much earlier, as a girl, in the house where she grew up, and it was there that she learned, without anyone teaching it to her in words, the thing that governed her life: that love is to keep the peace, to absorb the chaos, to hold the family so that it does not crumble, and never, never, to be herself one more weight.

It must be understood that Dore's never looked at her childhood as at a thing that had marked her, because the people of her generation and her milieu did not look at childhood that way; childhood was childhood, whatever it had been, and one did not go about turning it over nor blaming it for what one was as an adult. And so Dore's had never linked her saviour's temper to the house where she had grown up; she thought it was so, that it

was her temperament, that she had been born helpful and devoted. It took the Keeper, later, to help her see the thread that linked the appeasing girl to the saving woman, to understand that what she took for temperament was, in truth, a learning, a thing that had been taught her early and that she had taken for her nature. And there was, in seeing this, a liberation, because what is nature is not changed, but what is learning can be unlearned, and to understand that her saviour's temper was not nature but learning gave Dore's the hope of being able to change it, of being able to unlearn, already old, what she had learned as a girl, and of being able, at last, to be in another way than that of one who wears themselves out saving others.

Dore's grew up in a house where there was a shadow, and the shadow made of the house a place of tension, of dull fear, of fragile peace that could break at any moment. And the small Dore's, as happens often to the most sensitive child of a house like that, made herself, early, the one who appeased, the one who kept the peace, the one who placed herself between her parents and softened things, the one who foresaw the storms before they burst and tried to prevent them, the one who carried, on her child's shoulders, an adult's weight: that of holding a house that threatened to fall. She learned to read the atmos-

pheres, to anticipate the moods, to make herself small and useful, not to give trouble, not to have needs of her own so as not to add weight to a house that already had too much, and she learned, above all, that her worth lay in serving as a buffer, in absorbing what came, in keeping others safe at the cost of herself.

She remembered small things of that childhood, things she had kept without knowing why and that were, she understood now, the first lessons of her life. She remembered staying awake listening, when little, to gauge the state of the house before going down, to know whether she could be a girl or whether she had to be the appeaser. She remembered swallowing her own needs, not asking, not crying, not giving trouble, because the house already had trouble enough and she had learned that her worth lay in relieving and not in weighing. She remembered being praised precisely for that, for being so sensible, so helpful, so little bother, and how that praise, which ought to comfort a child, had taught her the wrong thing: that she was loved when she served, when she did not weigh, when she carried, and that therefore she had to serve and carry to be loved. A child praised for effacing themselves learns to efface themselves, and Does

learned it, and carried that effacement into her whole life, always serving to be loved, always carrying to be worth something, always last so that others could fit.

It was a stolen childhood, though Does never called it that, because she never allowed herself to see herself as a child robbed of childhood; she saw herself as a good daughter, a helpful girl, one who helped. But what she called helping was, in truth, a child playing the adult, carrying responsibilities that were not hers, caring for those who ought to care for her, and that early inversion, that of the child who cares for the parents instead of being cared for, marked Does so deep that it became her way of loving for the rest of her life: to love, for Does, was to care for the other at the cost of herself, was to put herself last, was to save, and any relationship in which she was not the saviour seemed to her, at bottom, a relationship in which she was good for nothing, had no place, was not needed.

There is a name for what Does became, though she never knew it nor needed to know it: the one who cares for everyone and for whom no one cares, the one who makes herself responsible for the happiness and the salvation of others as though it were her own, the one who does not know how to exist except at the ser-

vice of someone. It is a temper that forms early, in the houses where a child has to grow up too fast to hold what the adults do not hold, and that seems, from outside, a virtue — how devoted, how helpful, how good a soul — and that is, within, a wound, the wound of one who never learned that they had a right to be cared for, to have needs, to weigh, to simply be without having to serve. Does carried that wound from girlhood, and life, instead of curing it, went on giving her, one after another, men who needed to be saved, and each one of them confirmed the wound instead of curing it, because each one gave her one more person to carry, one more proof that she was only worth something carrying, one more excuse never to look at herself.

And the saddest is that Does, in carrying others, felt good, felt that she was doing what she ought, that she was a good daughter, a good wife, a good mother, and that sensation of doing good masked the wound from her, prevented her from seeing it, because it is hard to see as a wound a thing that everyone praises us for and that we ourselves take for a virtue. Who would tell Does that her devotion had a sick root? No one, because everyone profited from her devotion, everyone praised her for it, and she herself needed it to feel herself worth something. And so the wound passed unnoticed a whole lifetime, dis-

guised as a virtue, fed by the praise and by Does's own need to be needed, until the story, and the bottom, and the Keeper forced her, at last, to look beneath the virtue and to see the wounded girl who, beneath the saviour, went on carrying others in the never-said hope that someone, one day, would carry her.

And it was for that, she would understand much later, that she chose Aniceto, or that Aniceto chose her, because these things find each other: a woman trained to save finds a man who needs to be saved, and they recognise each other, and join, and the wheel begins. Does did not consciously choose a man who drank; but she was drawn, without knowing it, to someone who let her go on being what she had learned to be, the saviour, because it was in that role that she knew how to exist, it was the only love she knew. And when Aniceto died and Quim began to sink, Does went back to the role not only out of love for her son, but because the role was she, was her identity, was the place where she knew how to be in the world, and a woman without her role is a lost woman, and Does, without someone to save, would not know who she was.

This was the deep root of the thing, the one Dores did not see and that the story was going to show her: that she did not save her husband and then her son only out of love for them, she saved them also out of a need of her own, that of being the saviour, that of having a sinking one to shelter, because without that her life was left without the only meaning she had learned to give it as a girl. And there was in this a truth hard to swallow, that her sacrifice was not only generosity, it was also the repetition of a childhood wound, that of a child who learned that they are only worth something if they carry others, and who went on, an old woman, carrying others to feel herself worth something, even if carrying them was killing her.

There is a pattern that repeats itself in the families where someone drinks, and that passes from generation to generation without anyone deciding it, and Dores's family was an example of it, though she only saw it very late. The pattern is this: there is one who drinks and there is one who saves, and the two roles need each other and feed each other, and the children who grow up seeing their parents in those roles tend to repeat them, some in the role of the one who drinks, others in that of the one who saves. Dores had grown up in the role of the one who saves, and had carried it into the marriage; and Quim had grown up seeing

his mother save his father, and had learned the two roles, and the one that fell to him was the father's, that of the one who drinks and is saved. It was not chance, Dores would understand: Quim did not become like his father by bad luck, he became so because he had grown up in a house where he had learned, without words, that that was how a man was and that there was always a woman to save him. And there was in this a responsibility that was not guilt, but was responsibility: that the arrangement Dores had kept with her husband, that of saving instead of setting limits, had taught the son, without wishing it, the path he had come to follow.

And it was for that that to shut the door to Quim was, for Dores, also a way of breaking the pattern, of doing with the son the contrary of what she had done with the husband, of showing him, at last, that there was a woman in the family who knew how to set a limit, that the cycle of drinking and saving could stop, that it did not have to pass forever from generation to generation. Too late to change the past, but perhaps not too late for the son, and certainly not too late for herself, who in setting the limit broke, at least in herself, the chain that had bound her a whole lifetime to the role of saviour, and that perhaps, in break-

ing it in herself, broke it also for whoever came after, for the grandchildren, for the future, because the patterns one generation breaks are patterns the following ones no longer inherit.

There were, it is just to say, moments in Dore's life when someone offered her, without naming it, the chance to be cared for instead of caring. A neighbour, in times past, on seeing her worn, had offered to help her, and Dore had refused, as she always refused, there is no need, I manage; a sister, long ago, had wanted her to rest, to let herself be pampered a few days, and Dore had not known how, had felt uncomfortable being cared for, had fled to her tasks. Because to receive, for Dore, was harder than to give; to give was her place, her safe zone, and to receive put her in a strange place, vulnerable, where she did not know how to be. And she went on refusing, throughout her life, the rare hands that were stretched to her, always preferring to be the one who gives the hand to the one who receives it, and so she went on being more and more alone in her role, because a person who only knows how to give and never to receive drives away, without wishing it, those who would want to give to them, and is left only with those to whom they give, who are, often, those who consume them. And it was that, at bottom, the knot beneath the knot: not only did Dore make herself the saviour

of those who sank, she also refused to be sheltered by those who would want to shelter her, and those two things together — to always give and never receive — were the exact formula of a life draining away without ever being refilled.

But Does did not come to this truth alone, nor quickly, because it is one of the hardest truths there is, that of discovering that the thing we take for our greatest virtue — the giving, the sacrifice, the saving — has, deep down, a root that is no virtue at all, it is a wound, it is a fear, it is the hunger of a girl who was never cared for and who learned to make herself indispensable to guarantee a place in a world that taught her that she, by herself, was not enough. That truth Does would only reach at the bottom, with the help of a Keeper, after a night of fear that would force her, at last, to look at what she was doing and at the wounded child who, beneath the mother who saved, went on trying, by saving others, to save herself.

CHAPTER FOUR

Always to give



It had not always been so, and Does remembered, with longing, a time when the relationship with her son was another thing, when Quim came to see her for pleasure, when they talked, when they laughed, when he told her of his life and she of hers, a relationship of mother and son like the others, with its joys and its normal frictions. That time had gone on sinking with the son, as the drink took him, and the relationship had gone on shrinking, losing the conversations, the laughter, the pleasure, until there was left only the request, only the transaction, only Quim coming to fetch money and the mother giving it. And Does wept, within, that impoverishment of the relationship, the passage from a full relationship to a relationship reduced to a request, because it was like watching die, slowly, not only the son, but the bond between the two, emptied

of all the good it had had until there was left only the dry bone of the request. And perhaps it was also that longing for the relationship that had been, as much as the love and the fear, that bound her to the giving, because giving was what remained of the bond, and to stop giving seemed to cut the last thread, however poor, that still linked her to her son.

Dores's relationship with her son had reduced itself, over the years, to a single dynamic, repeated without end: Quim asked, and Dores gave. And it was in that dynamic, in the always-giving, that one saw what Dores's love had become, and the harm that love, with the best of intentions, did to the two.

It must be said, to understand Dores and not to judge her, that Quim's descent was slow, and that each yielding of hers, seen in isolation, always made sense. No one decides, from one day to the next, to finance the ruin of a son; one comes there one step at a time, and each step, in the moment, seems reasonable. The first time Quim asked, it was a real emergency, and what mother does not attend to a son's emergency? The second, it was another, and one could no longer let fall whom one had helped before. And so, request by request, each one reasonable in itself, Dores went on descending a stairway whose bottom

she had never decided to reach, without there ever being a step on which it was evident that she had to stop there, because each step was only a little lower than the previous. That is how these things happen, not by one great wrong decision, but by a succession of small reasonable decisions that added together give a ruin, and Dore, like so many, had descended the stairway one sensible step at a time, and only there at the bottom, on looking up, did she understand how far from the surface she had come, and that none of the steps, alone, had taken her there, but all of them together, yes.

At first, when Quim began to sink, the requests were sporadic and had an air of real emergency: a late rent, a debt that got him into trouble, a serious strait. And Dore attended, because she was the mother, because she was not going to leave her son in the street, because any mother would attend. But the requests, once begun, did not stop; they multiplied, spaced out less and less, and Dore went on finding herself giving more and more often, more and more money, until the giving became the normal, until her son's visits were almost only that, requests, and until she herself counted, in the tight budget of her pension, on the part that went to get Quim out of one more hole.

There were things Dores sold, or pawned, or ceased to have, to give to her son, and each one was a small loss she did not tally but that added up. She sold some earrings that had been her mother's, one of the few things that remained to her of her mother, to plug a debt of Quim's, and was left without them, and it hurt her, but she gave. She ceased to put aside the little she put by for old age, for a strait, for an unforeseen thing, because the little went all to the son, and she was left with no net at all, with nothing set aside, at the mercy of the first unforeseen thing. She deprived herself of small things and of large things, without ever adding up the total, because to add up the total would be to see the size of what she gave, and to see the size would be to have to stop, and she did not want to stop, or could not. And so she went on stripping herself, piece by piece, of the little she had and even of the memories, like her mother's earrings, all to feed a well that did not fill, and when, later, she did the sums, she understood that she had given her son not only money, but pieces of herself, memories, security, future, all thrown into a bottomless well in the name of a salvation that never came.

And Dore's money was not much. It was a small pension, what had been left over from a life of straits, and Dore began to deprive herself to give to her son: she ceased to buy what she needed, cut into what was hers, went on living with less and less so as to have something to give Quim when he came to ask. She deprived herself of the necessary to feed her son's drink, though she did not say it so, though she said to herself that it was to help him, that it was to get him out of it; but the money went to the drink, directly or indirectly, and Dore, at bottom, knew it, and gave all the same, and deprived herself all the same, because to say no to her son was a thing she did not know how to do, that she had never learned, that seemed to her a betrayal.

There was one time, of the many, that stayed with Dore as an example of everything. Quim had come to ask, she had hesitated, and he had said to her a thing that disarmed her: if my mother does not help me, who helps me? You are my mother. And Dore, on hearing that, had given, of course, because it was exactly the key that made her yield, that of being the mother, that of if she did not help no one would help. But later, thinking, she understood what was crooked in that sentence, however true it seemed: that Quim used the fact of her being his mother as a lever, that he transformed her love into an obligation to

give, that he said, at bottom, you are my mother, so you have to give to me. And it was not so, Does understood slowly: to be a mother did not oblige her to give what sank him; to be a mother obliged her, rather, to want his good, and his good was perhaps, precisely, not to give. Quim's sentence, you are my mother, which seemed an appeal to love, was in truth a blackmail of love, and Does had to learn to distinguish the two things, to refuse the blackmail without refusing the love, to say I am your mother, and it is for being it that I do not give you what sinks you, turning against the blackmail the very motherhood it invoked.

And there was, in Does's giving, a thing she did not see and that made everything sadder: that the giving was, also, the only way left to her of being with her son. Because Quim no longer came for anything else; he did not come to see her, to talk, to be with his mother; he came to ask, and the request was the pretext of the visits, and Does, at bottom, knew it, and gave in part to have her son there, even if to ask, because a son asking was better than an absent son, and the visit of the request was the only visit left to her. And there was in this a deep sadness, that of a mother who buys, with the money she gives, a few minutes of the presence of a son who otherwise would not come, that of a

love reduced to a transaction, in which the coin of exchange for the son's presence was the mother's money. Does would never say it so, would never think it so, but it was so, and perhaps it was that, more even than the fear, the deepest reason why it cost her so much to close the tap: because to close the tap was to risk losing even that, even the visits of the request, even the bought minutes, was to risk being left without her son at all, and that, for a mother, is a fear that defeats almost all the others.

There was a time when Quim asked her for a large sum, too large, a serious debt, and Does did not have it, and instead of saying I do not have it, son, I cannot, she did a thing that would haunt her afterward: she borrowed, she herself, to give to her son. She got into debt to pay Quim's debt, put herself into a strait to get him out of a strait, and Quim took the money and his debt was paid and hers was left unpaid, and months later Quim was in another strait the same, because the debt was not the problem, the problem was the drink, and to plug the debt without touching the drink was to plug a hole in a wall that went on opening holes. Does understood, vaguely, with that debt she took on for herself, that she was doing a thing that had no end,

that she could give everything she had and more, and the son would go on sinking, because she was feeding the sinking and calling that saving him.

She began, in that time, to hide things in the house, and it was a sign of how far the thing had come. She hid the money, in different places, moved it from place to place, because Quim, when he came and she did not give, or when he came and she was not there, searched, and sometimes took. She hid the things of value, the little she had, the gold of a lifetime, because she was afraid it would disappear. And there was a deep humiliation in this, that of a mother who has to hide her goods from her own son, that of living in her own house as one who defends themselves from a thief, and that thief being the son she had raised, whom she had nursed, whom she had kept watch over as a child. Does did it with shame, without telling anyone, and each hiding place was a stab, because it was to admit, in gestures, what she could not admit in words: that her son had become someone from whom she had to guard her things, someone she could no longer trust inside the house, and that the drink had robbed her not only of her son but of the trust, the quiet, the very safety of the home.

And even so she gave. Even hiding, even distrusting, even hurt, when Quim asked to her face, Dores ended up giving, because the no stuck in her throat would not come out, because the image of the son going hungry or cold or worse was too much for her to bear, because a whole life of saving does not come apart in a no. And she was left, after giving, with the bitter sensation of one who has done a thing they know they should not have, the momentary relief of having attended to her son mixed with the deep certainty of having fed what destroyed him, and that mixture, the relief and the guilt in the same gesture, was the taste of each yielding, and Dores knew it well, because she felt it time after time, without managing to stop.

But even understanding, she could not stop, and the reason was simple and terrible: she was afraid of what would happen if she stopped. She was afraid that, without her money, Quim would fall deeper, do himself a disaster, end up in the street, or worse; she was afraid that, if she closed the tap, she would be responsible for what happened to him. And Quim, without knowing how to say it or knowing it too well, used that fear, came with stories that stoked it, if his mother did not help him this and that would happen, and Dores, terrified of being the cause of a disaster of her son's, gave, always gave, hostage to the fear that not to give

would be worse. She did not see, then, what the story would show her: that in always giving she was not preventing her son's bottom, she was putting it off indefinitely, and that a bottom put off forever is a whole life sinking slowly, without ever touching the ground that perhaps, only perhaps, would make the son push himself upward.

There was a word for what Dores did, though she did not know it nor needed to know it: she helped her son to go on drinking. Not because she wished to, of course, but in effect, because each yielding took from Quim a consequence that perhaps would make him stop. When Quim spent his on drink and was left with no money for the rent, the natural consequence would be the strait of the unpaid rent; but the mother came and paid, and the consequence disappeared, and Quim was left free to spend the next on drink again. When Quim got into a debt because of the drink, the consequence would be having to face it; but the mother came and plugged it, and the consequence disappeared. And so, yielding after yielding, Dores went on removing from her son's path all the stones the drink put there, all the consequences that perhaps would make him stop to think, and in removing them she left the path smooth for him to go on drinking without ever stumbling on anything. She called this helping

him; it was, in effect, helping him to drink, because it took from him the reasons to stop, and a man from whom the reasons to stop are taken does not stop. Does did not see this, or saw it vaguely and pushed it away, because it was unbearable, it was to admit that her love served her son's illness, that she was, without wishing it, complicit in what destroyed him; but it was true, and the story was going to force her to see it.

And while she put off her son's bottom, Does dug her own. Each yielding took a little more from her, of the money, of the strength, of the peace, of the house, and Does went on wearing away, went on ruining herself, went on filling with a debt that was not only of money, it was of life, and the worst is that she saw no way out, because the only way out she could conceive, to stop giving, seemed to her impossible, a betrayal, an abandonment, and so she went on, caught in the wheel of the always-giving, sinking with her son in the name of saving him, with no one yet to tell her that there was another way to love him that was not to sink with him.

CHAPTER FIVE

The chorus of the village



Dores had carried hers in secret her whole life, first the husband and then the son, without sharing, without asking for help, with the shame of one who thinks they are the only one. And one of the things that most relieved her, when at last she opened up, was to discover that she was not, that there were others, many, carrying the same behind the closed doors of Véspera, and that to share with them, to cease to carry in hiding, was already half a relief. But it was not a discovering all at once, it was through the women, one by one, and through two in particular, Rosalina and Encarnação, who put before her eyes, without knowing it, the two paths that opened before her.

Encarnação came first, because Encarnação died first.

They had been friends as girls, Dores and Encarnação, of the kind to go to the river together and to court at the same corner, and Encarnação had been, she too, of those who save. She had had a son, Aurélio, who sank in the drink like Quim, and Encarnação had given him everything, deprived herself of everything, and had never set a door. Dores remembered going to see her, in her friend's last years, and finding her each time smaller inside her clothes, with her hands trembling from a tiredness that was no longer tiredness, it was another thing. On one of those visits, of the last ones, Encarnação was sitting at the kitchen table counting coins from a saucer, slowly, separating them into little piles, and Dores asked her what she was doing, and Encarnação said, without lifting her eyes from the coins, I'm seeing if there's enough for Aurélio until Thursday, Dores, he's got something to pay. And Dores looked at the little piles of coins, which were the last money of a woman who no longer had what to eat, and looked at her friend, who was a shadow, and wanted to say something to her, and Encarnação, who read her face, said only, before she could speak, don't say anything to me, Dores, I know what you're going to tell me and I don't want to hear it. He's my son. While I have a coin, he won't

go hungry. And she went back to the coins. And Dores said nothing, because she herself, at home, did the same, and one who does the same thing has no mouth to correct it.

Encarnação died soon after, worn, of a tiredness of a life saving a son who sank all the same, and Aurélio, he, had sunk all the same, because the mother's sacrifice had not saved him, it had only killed her first. And the village wept for her as one weeps for a saint. Dores was on the church terrace, on the way out, and heard the women, oh Encarnação, what a mother, she gave her life for her son, she was a saint, and Custódia from the pharmacy, who always had a word for everything, said, now that was a mother's love, she gave everything, kept nothing for herself. And Dores, on the terrace, with the sun beating on the back of her neck, wept for her friend so too, with admiration for the sacrifice, and carried home Custódia's sentence, now that was love, she gave everything, kept nothing for herself, and for a long time she thought it was a praise. Only much later, with Rosalina working on her, did that sentence come back to her turned inside out, and Dores understood that the village had been mistaken, that there had been no sainthood there at all, there had been a tragedy: a woman who had let herself die saving one who did not save himself, two shipwrecks where per-

haps one could have been saved. And she understood, with a shiver, that she was looking at her own funeral, at her own terrace, at her own Custódia saying of her, a few years hence, oh Dorés, what a mother, she gave everything, kept nothing for herself, she was a saint, over a coffin where she was to be the next Encarnação, wept for as a saint and dead in vain.

Rosalina was the other path, and Rosalina was alive.

Rosalina had had a son like Quim, Tó, sunk in the drink, always asking, and Rosalina, at a certain point, after years of saving him, had done a thing that scandalised the village: she cut off. She told her son that she gave nothing more, that the door of the house was shut to the drink, and she kept to it, however much it cost her, however much she wept, however much the village pointed at her as an unnatural mother. Dorés, at first, had thought that of an unbelievable harshness, and when she crossed paths with Rosalina in the street she barely spoke to her, with a silent reproach, as one who does not want to catch the illness of one who lets a son fall.

It was on an October afternoon, at the door of the shop, that the thing changed. Dorés was coming out with the bag of rice, and Rosalina was going in, and they crossed on the threshold, and

Rosalina, who saw deep because she had already been through all of it, stopped, and looked at Does, at her thinness, at the colour of her face, and said, without circling, with the gentle harshness of one who has learned at their own cost, Does, you have the face I had. And Does, who was going to answer the usual, I'm well, Rosalina, it's the heat, could not, because Rosalina put her hand on her arm, there at the door of the shop, and said, come with me to the bench in the square, I have a thing to tell you and you need to hear it, and Benvinda, from the counter, saw the two of them go out together and said nothing, but kept it.

They sat on the bench in the square, under the plane tree, and Rosalina said to her the thing that stayed, and said it looking at the fountain and not at Does, because there are truths that are better said from the side: Does, you are doing what I did so many years, and I tell you what no one told me. You are not saving him. You are paying so that he does not touch the bottom, and while he does not touch the bottom he will never want to climb. The money you give him does not save him, it cushions his fall enough for him to go on falling without pain. If you truly love him, let him touch the bottom, which is the only thing that perhaps will make him look up. And while you do not do it, he

sinks and you sink with him, and the two of you die, and that, Does, that is not love, it is only fear of letting him fall. And Does, on the bench, opened her mouth to defend herself, to say but you don't know how he is, and Rosalina cut her off, I know, woman, I know better than you, mine did the same, and Does fell silent, because it was true, Rosalina knew.

And Rosalina told her, there on the bench and on other afternoons that followed, how her crossing had been, and Does heard her as one hears news of a country into which they are going to have to enter. She told her of the first night when she shut the door to Tó, and how he knocked, and shouted, and how she stayed on the inside with the dishcloth biting between her teeth so as not to open, which was the only way she had of not crying out for her son. She told her of the weeks when the village cut her, when her own sister stopped greeting her at Mass, when she went to the fountain and the conversations stopped when she arrived. She told her of the terror, of the nights when she telephoned those she knew in the big town to ask whether they had seen Tó, only to know if he was alive, without ever giving him a penny. But she told her also the other side: how, with time, the house became hers again, how the sleep came back, how she ceased to hide things and to lock the drawers; and how

Tó, without his mother's net, went on descending to a bottom, and how from that bottom, at the end of a very long time and without any guarantee, he had begun to sketch a climb. I do not promise you that yours will be saved, Does, said Rosalina, no one promises that, and there are those who are not saved however much the mother does or does not do. What I promise you is that you save yourself, if you shut the door, and that you give your son the only chance he has, which is to touch the bottom. To save yourself is certain; to save him is only a chance; but it is more of a chance than he has now, which, with your net beneath him, is none.

There was an afternoon, of those, when Rosalina took Does home, and Does noticed Rosalina's house, which was the house of a woman who had gone back to living: it had flowers at the window, and a smell of cake in the oven, and an unfinished crochet blanket resting on the chair, of the kind only made by women who have their heads free to make things without haste. And Does, who had at home the fear and the ear listening for the doorbell, looked at Rosalina's unfinished blanket as one looks at a thing of another world, and thought, without saying it, this is what she gained in shutting the door, a quiet afternoon to do crochet, and I, who did not shut it, have not sat down in years

without my heart leaping. And she understood, in that blanket, more than in all the words, the difference between the two paths: that Encarnação had died with the coins separated into little piles, and Rosalina lived with an unfinished blanket, and that between Encarnação's coins and Rosalina's blanket lay all the difference between drowning and staying on the bank.

There were still, in the village, those who saw the thing in another way, and Dores heard those voices too, which pulled her back. Custódia from the pharmacy, who had wept for Encarnação as a saint, said to Dores, when she saw her giving to Quim, you do right, woman, a mother is a mother, while there is bread in the house there is bread for the son; and a cousin of Aniceto's, Idalina, who appeared now and then, said to her one never saw a son left helpless, Dores, that thing of Rosalina's is the doing of one with no heart. And those voices comforted Dores in her yielding, gave her reason, made of her always-giving a virtue and of Rosalina's limit a cruelty, and it was comfortable to hear them, because they told her what she wanted to hear. But Dores began to distrust them, because she saw what the always-giving did to her, and she saw the unfinished blanket on Rosalina's chair, and the evidence contradicted the comfort. The voices that comforted her were pushing her toward

Encarnação's path, that of the coins in little piles and the coffin wept for as a saint's; Rosalina's voice, which troubled her, pointed her to the harder path but perhaps the only one with a way out. And Dores had to learn to distrust the comfort and to hear the discomfort, because the truth, sometimes, is on the side of what it costs us to hear, and not on the side of what gives us reason.

Rosalina, with time, became for Dores the only person with whom she could speak of that without shame, because she had been through the same and did not judge her. The others, even the well-intentioned, either pitied Dores in a way that humiliated her, or gave her easy advice of those who never went through it, bring him into line, give him nothing more, it is easy to say; only Rosalina knew the strait of a mother in that situation, knew that it was not lack of sense that made Dores give, it was a deep web of love and of fear and of guilt from which one does not get out with a piece of advice. And so Rosalina's words weighed, when she told Dores to stop, because they were not the easy advice of one who is outside, they were the hard experience of one who had been inside and got out.

They were two mothers, then, Rosalina and Encarnação, and two paths, and two outcomes, and Dores saw herself between them, at the crossroads. And she began, slowly, to ask herself the unthinkable: and if Rosalina, the mother the village had called unnatural, had after all loved her son better than she loved Quim? And if to cut off, far from being abandonment, were the only real chance of salvation, for the mother and for the son? And if the love she gave, that of always saving, were, after all, Encarnação's path, the one that kills the mother and does not save the son?

And Dores stayed with that, and it hurt her, because it was exactly what she did not want to hear and what, at bottom, she knew to be true. That night, at home, she went to the chest of drawers, to the sewing box, and took out from there not the wedding portrait but the empty case where her mother's earrings had been, the ones she had sold a few years before to plug a debt of Quim's, and she was left with the empty case in her hand, lined with a velvet already worn into the shape of the earrings that were not there, and she thought of Encarnação separating the coins into little piles, and of Rosalina with the unfinished blanket, and of the empty case that was what remained to

her of her mother after a debt of her son's, and she understood that she had been, her whole life, emptying cases to fill a well, and that the well did not fill, and that the cases did not fill again.

CHAPTER SIX

To save is not to love



There was resistance, of course, and the resistance had a name Dores did not use but felt: the pride of a saviour. Because Dores had, without admitting it, a certain pride in being the one who gave, the one who endured, the one who did not give up, and that pride was linked to her idea of herself as a good mother, a good person, a woman of worth. To accept that her saving was not a virtue, that perhaps it did more harm than good, was to wound that pride, was to have to come down from the pedestal of the self-denying mother to the ground of a woman who had perhaps been mistaken, and that cost, because the pedestal, however uncomfortable, gave her a dignity, a meaning, an identity. And it took Dores accepting to lose that pedestal — that of the mother who sacrifices herself, whom the village admired and lamented — to be able to change, because

while she clung to the image of the self-denying mother she could not do what seemed the contrary of it, to shut the door. She had to accept to seem, in the eyes of the village and her own, a less self-denying mother, to be, in truth, a better mother; she had to come down from the pedestal of sacrifice to the ground of good sense, and it was a humiliating but necessary descent, because it was on the pedestal of sacrifice that she was sinking, and it was on the ground of good sense that she could save herself.

Rosalina's sentence worked in Dores for weeks, and led her, slowly, to a discovery that called into question everything she had always believed about love: that to save and to love, which she had always taken for the same thing, could be, after all, different things, and sometimes even contrary.

This discovery — that to save and to love could be different things — was perhaps the most important of Dores's whole story, because it was the one that changed everything, and it was also one of the hardest to accept, because it went against a certainty so old and so deep that to call it into question was like calling into question the ground. Everyone had taught her, her whole life, that a good mother saves her child, that a mother's

love is to give everything, that a mother sacrifices herself; and the whole village went on teaching it to her, every day, applauding the mothers who sacrificed themselves and censuring those who set limits. Dores had, around her, almost no one who told her the contrary, except Rosalina and the Keeper; everyone else, and her own inner voice, told her that to save was to love, that to give was the duty, that to shut the door was unnatural. And so the discovery that perhaps it was the other way around was so solitary and so hard, because Dores had to make it almost against everyone, against the village, against what she had learned, against her own inner voice, clinging only to the evidence of the facts and to the words of two women who had seen deeper, and to go against everyone is one of the hardest things there is, above all when what is at stake is the idea we have of what it is to be a good mother.

Dores had learned, as a girl, that to love was to save, and had lived sixty-some years without ever calling that equation into question. To love her father was to save him, to love her husband was to save him, to love her son was to save him: love, for Dores, was always said in the verb to save, and a mother who did not save her child was not, in her head, a mother in earnest. So Rosalina's idea cost her so much, that of not saving; because

not to save seemed to her, simply, not to love, and she loved Quim more than anything, and therefore she had to save him, and that was that.

There was a proof that weighed more than any reasoning, and Dores saw it with her own eyes, one morning, at the door of the shop. She was coming out with the bag of bread when Tó passed in the street, on the other side, Rosalina's son, with a sack of cement on his shoulder and the firm step of one going to a job, and he greeted her from afar, with his hand, good day, Dona Dores, without turning his eyes away, without the air of one who flees, and went on his way with the cement on his back. And Dores stayed still at the door, with the bag of bread in her hand, watching him move off, and there came to her memory, over the figure of Tó at his work, the other figure, that of Aurélio, Encarnação's son, saved to the end, deprived of everything by the mother who killed herself saving him, whom she had seen, the last time, leaning against a wall in the square, at midday, with his face swollen and his eyes on the ground, begging from those who passed. The two sons, before her, in the same village: the one the mother had let fall, carrying a sack of cement; the one the mother had saved until she died, leaning against a wall. If saving saved, it ought to be the other way around, and it was

so, and Dores, at the door of the shop, with the bread in her hand, had before her eyes, alive, the proof that her path led to the sinking of both and the other perhaps to the salvation of both, and it was that image, more than any reasoning, that shook her faith of a lifetime, because one thing is to hear oneself told that one is wrong, another is to see Tó with the cement and Aurélio against the wall on the same day.

But Rosalina's sentence had opened a chink in that certainty, and through that chink an uncomfortable light began to enter. Dores began to look at what her saving did to Quim, and what she saw did not confirm the equation, it contradicted it. Her saving did not better her son; it kept him the same, or worsened him. Each time she got him out of a strait, Quim did not come out of the strait nearer to changing, he came out nearer to making the next strait, because he had learned that there was always the mother to get him out, and one who learns that there is always a net has no reason to stop falling. Dores's saving had become, without her wishing it, a net that allowed her son to go on falling without consequences, and without consequences there is no change, because it is from the consequences of their acts

that a person learns, and Does, in taking from her son the consequences, took from him, without knowing it, the only thing that perhaps would make him change.

And she understood, with pain, that Rosalina was right: that she did not love her son in saving him, or not only; in saving him, she was putting off his bottom, cushioning his fall, allowing him to sink comfortably, and that, however much it came from love, was not love in its effect, it was the contrary, it was a soft push to go on sinking. And she understood too the other half of the truth, the one that hurt her even more: that part of what made her save her son was not even his good, it was her fear — the fear of seeing him fall, the fear of being responsible, the fear of not being needed, the fear of ceasing to be the saviour. She saved her son, in part, to spare herself the anguish of seeing him fall, and that, however human it was, was not a clean love, it was a love with fear inside, and her fear was costing her son the chance to touch the bottom and perhaps climb.

It cost her, this discovery, because it called into question not only what she did now with her son, but everything she had been her whole life. If to save was not to love, then what had her life been? A whole life of saving — the father, the husband, the

son —, a whole life of thinking that that was love, and to discover now, old, that perhaps she had loved badly, that perhaps her saving had done more harm than good, was to call into question the meaning of everything, it was a kind of mourning of what she had thought was her greatest virtue. And Does resisted that discovery, as one resists a truth that undoes us, because it was easier to go on believing that to save was to love, even if it was killing her, than to accept that she had been mistaken her whole life about what it is to love. But the truth, when it is the truth, does not let itself be kept away, and that of save and love being able to be different things went on imposing itself on Does, against her will, proof after proof, until she could no longer not see it.

And there was the question of the register, the question of the shelf, the one Does had never heard but that governed her life: what am I carrying that is not mine? And the answer, for Does, was clear as water, now that the light entered through the chink: she carried her son's illness, her son's recovery, her son's bottom, as though they were hers to carry, when they were his. Quim's drink was Quim's; the decision to stop, if it came, would have to be Quim's; the bottom that perhaps would make him change was Quim's to touch. None of that was Does's to carry,

and Dores carried everything, took everything off her son's back onto hers, and in doing so not only crushed herself but prevented her son from carrying what was his, which was, after all, the only thing that perhaps would save him: the weight of his own choices.

She thought much, in that time, of the difference between helping and saving, because she understood that she had confused the two things her whole life. To help, she understood slowly, is to give someone what they need to rise on their own feet; to save, in the sense in which she saved, is to do for the other what only they can do for themselves, is to carry them instead of letting them walk, and that, far from raising them, keeps them fallen, dependent, incapable. A mother helps a son when she gives him the conditions to get himself out; a mother saves a son badly when she gets him out herself, time after time, from the consequences of his acts, because so she takes from him what he needs to change, which is to feel the weight of what he does. Dores did not help Quim; she saved him, in the bad sense, did for him what only he could do, took from him the consequences, and in doing so kept him fallen, because a man who is always saved never has a reason to rise. And to understand this difference was, for Dores, a turning point, because it showed her

that her saving, which she took for the height of love, was in truth the contrary of help, was a carrying that prevented her son from learning to walk, and that to help him in earnest was perhaps, paradoxically, to stop saving him.

And there was a hard humility in this discovery, that of admitting that she did not have the power to save her son, that that power was not in her hands however much she sacrificed herself. Does had always believed, at bottom, that if she gave enough, loved enough, sacrificed enough, she would manage to save her son, as a kind of exchange: so much sacrifice, so much salvation. And she had to accept, now, that it was not so, that there was no exchange, that she could give everything and sacrifice herself to death and the son not be saved, because his salvation did not depend on her sacrifice, it depended on his choice, and that was the hardest thing to accept for a mother who had made of sacrifice her religion: that the sacrifice bought no one's salvation, that one could give one's life for a son and the son be lost all the same, that a mother's love, however great, did not have the power to save one who did not want to save themselves.

She could not, on understanding this, change at once, because between understanding and managing there is an abyss, above all when what one has to do goes against the instinct of a lifetime and against the deepest fear of a mother. She argued much with herself, in that time, about what it was to be a good mother, because her whole idea of a good mother was bound to the saving, and to unbind it hurt like unbinding a part of herself. A good mother does not abandon her son, the old voice told her; a good mother gives everything for her son; a good mother never shuts the door. And Dores had to answer that voice, with the help of Rosalina and the Keeper, that one thing is to abandon and another is to set a limit, that to give everything for the son does not mean to give everything the son asks, that to shut the door to the drink is not to shut the door to the son. She had to dismantle, piece by piece, her idea of a good mother, and build another, in which to be a good mother could include saying no, setting a limit, letting the son face the consequences, protecting herself. And it was a new idea, and strange, and it went against everything she had heard her whole life about what a mother is, but it was, she understood slowly, a truer idea, because the old idea, that of the mother who gives everything and never shuts the door, led to Encarnação, to the consumed mother and the

son sunk all the same, and the new one, that of the mother who loves and sets limits, led to Rosalina, to the living mother and the son with a chance. And between an idea that killed and another that gave life, Dores had to choose the second, however much the first was the one she had learned, because the proof was in plain sight of which of the two was after all the true love.

But the equation had broken, and that was already much: Dores could no longer believe, as she had always believed, that to save her son was to love him; she began to suspect the contrary, to suspect that she loved him badly in saving him, and that perhaps she would love him better, and herself too, if she learned the thing Rosalina had done and that still seemed to her impossible: to stop saving him, to let him touch the bottom, and to love him from a bank instead of drowning with him.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The night of fear



There was a night that changed everything, the night when the fear ceased to be a shadow and became a concrete thing, the night when Does was afraid of her son in her own house, afraid in earnest, and when she understood, in her body and not only in her head, the bottom she had reached.

It had been a bad day, that one, with a foreboding since the afternoon, because Does had learned to sense the bad nights as one senses a storm, by a change in the air. She had known, by the village's means, that Quim was worse, that he had got into trouble, that he drank more than ever, and she had spent the afternoon with her heart tight, waiting, because she knew that an afternoon like that usually ended in a night ring. And it ended.

It was the night ring, the ring she knew and dreaded, the finger on the button without letting go, and Dores, on the other side of the door, with her heart leaping, knew at once that Quim came in a bad way, came drunk, came in the shadow. And she hesitated, as she always hesitated, between opening and not opening, and she opened, as she always opened, because he was her son, because she was afraid of what would happen if she did not open, because never, in her whole life, had she managed to leave a door shut to a child. And Quim came in, and he was Quim and he was not, he was the drink with her son's face, and he came to ask, and he came worse than ever, and when Dores, that time, hesitated to give, when Rosalina's sentence gave her, for an instant, the courage to hesitate, Quim changed, became another, and Dores saw, that night, in the son she loved, a thing that terrified her.

There had been signs, before that night, that things were going that way, and Dores, looking back, saw them, but had not wanted to see them in the moment, because to see them was to have to act. Quim had come, other times, with the drink making him harsher, more demanding, and Dores had noticed the fear growing, slowly, visit after visit, but had told herself that it was her son, that he would do her no harm, that she exaggerated. A

mother finds it very hard to admit that she is afraid of a son, and Does had put off that admission as much as she could, finding excuses, minimising, telling herself that it was the drink and not the son, that it passed, that it was nothing. Until the night when it was something, when the fear ceased to be a suspicion she could minimise and became a certainty she could not deny, and it was that passage, from the deniable fear to the undeniable fear, that made of that night the night that changed everything, because what can be denied lets itself be put off, and what cannot be denied forces one to act.

There is no need to tell what happened that night, and there are things that are better told by what they leave than by what they are. It must be said, with the care the subject asks, that the Quim of that night was not a bad man, he was a sick man, and that the fear Does felt was not fear of a wicked one, it was fear of what the drink made of a son who, sober, was incapable of frightening her. And that, far from easing the fear, made it more terrible, because it was a fear without hatred, a fear with love inside, the fear of a mother who sees the drink take hold of her son and transform him into someone she does not recognise and from whom she has to defend herself. Does could not hate the Quim of that night, because she saw, beneath the man who frightened

her, the boy she had raised, and that impossibility of hating, that love that persisted beneath the fear, was what made everything so harrowing: it would be easier if she could hate, if she could make of her son an enemy and cast him from her heart; but she could not, she loved him, and she had to learn to defend herself from someone she loved, to protect herself from a son without ceasing to love him, and there is no balance harder than that, that of one who has to guard themselves from one they love.

It stayed that Does was afraid, physically afraid, afraid in her own house, of her own son; it stayed that she shut herself in a room with her heart galloping, waiting for it to pass; it stayed that, when Quim at last went, or at last fell asleep, or the night at last ended, Does stayed sitting in the dark, trembling, understanding that she had come to a place she had never thought she would come to: to be afraid of a son, to be a hostage at home, to live in dread of the doorbell and the door, she, in the house that was hers, in the home she had made with so much love.

There is a particular solitude in the mother who is afraid of a son, and Does came to know it that night in all its bitterness. Because to whom does a mother tell that she is afraid of her

own son? To whom does she say it, without betraying him, without exposing him, without condemning him in the eyes of others? Does could not say it to anyone, because to say it was to accuse her son, was to put him into the mouth of the village as a man of whom his own mother is afraid, and her instinct of a lifetime, that of protecting, that of covering, prevented her from exposing him even now, even with fear. And so Does carried alone that monstrous fear, the fear of a loved son, without being able to share it, without relief, and that solitude of the silent fear was perhaps the worst of all, because the fear that can be said divides itself and eases, and the fear that has to be kept silent stays whole, gnawing within, and Does had kept it silent for a long time, smiling for the village and trembling at home, defending her son out there and dreading him in here, split in two between the love she showed and the fear she hid.

When at last the night passed, and the house went silent, and Does dared to leave the room where she had shut herself, she walked through the house in the dark, still trembling, and went on noticing the wreckage that night had left, and each sign was a stab. It does not matter what was in disorder or broken; it matters that Does, recomposing the house at dawn, alone, with her hands trembling, understood that she was doing what she

had done so many times with her husband, years before: recomposing, at dawn, in silence, alone, the harm of a man whom the drink had unhinged, erasing the signs, putting the house in order as though nothing were the matter, as though she could, by tidying the house, tidy also what went on within. And it was the repetition of the gesture, recomposing the house at dawn as she had recomposed her husband's, that gave her, more than anything, the measure of where she had come to: that she was living, with her son, the same night she had lived with his father, redoing the same gestures of distress and of covering-up, caught in the same cycle, condemned, it seemed, to recompose forever the houses that the men she loved unhinged, first the husband, now the son, always she, always at dawn, always alone, always tidying harm that was not hers.

And it was on that night, in the dark, after the fear, that Does touched the bottom, and the bottom was this perception: that her love for her son, her saving without end, her always-giving, had brought her there, to being afraid of him at home, to being his hostage, to giving what she did not have to a man who frightened her. It was not the son who had brought her there, or not only; it was she, it was her saving, it was the door she always opened, it was the money she always gave, it was the refusal to

set a limit, that had created, over the years, this situation in which she lived terrified in her own house of a son who had learned that he could do anything because the mother endured anything. Her love without limits had created a son without limits, and a son without limits, in the shadow of the drink, was a son one could be afraid of, and Dorez was, and the fear was the bitter harvest of a life of not knowing how to say no.

The most terrible of that night, and what most marked her, was to discover that she was afraid of a person she loved, and that those two things — the love and the fear — could live at the same time in a mother's breast, directed at the same person, without cancelling each other. Dorez had always thought that love kept away fear, that to a mother who loves her son the son cannot give fear; and she discovered, that night, that it was not so, that one could love and dread at the same time, that the love for her son did not prevent her from dreading what the drink made of him, and that to live with those two things together, the love and the fear for the same person, was a particular torture, because the fear told her to flee and the love told her to stay, and she was left split between the two, unable to flee from one she loved nor to love without fear one she dreaded. And it was that splitting, the love and the fear pulling her to opposite sides, that the night

put before her with a clarity she could no longer ignore, and it was from that unbearable clarity that there was born, at last, the will to change, because a person can live a long time in a bad situation while they manage not to see it, and ceases to be able to bear it the instant they see it whole, and Does, that night, saw hers whole.

She thought, that night, of Aniceto, of the husband who had also frightened her, in his time, when he drank, and she understood, with a cold horror, that she was living for the second time the same night, first with the husband and now with the son, a hostage at home of a man she loved and whom the drink transformed, and that her life had been, at bottom, this: two crossings of fear, separated by a short rest, always in the same water, always saving and always dreading, always giving everything to men who sank and who, in sinking, dragged her with them. There was, in the midst of the fear of that night, an instant of a cold lucidity that marked her: on seeing herself shut in a room of her own house, waiting for the danger to pass, Does thought, with a clarity that froze her, this is not right. She did not think I have to help my son, nor what will become of him; she thought, for the first time, about herself: this is not right, I should not be like this, shut in a room, afraid, in my own house. And it was a

new thought, because for the first time in her whole life Does put herself at the centre of a thought, judged her own situation from the point of view of what she, Does, deserved or did not deserve, instead of judging it from the point of view of her son. And that small revolution, that of thinking this is not right for me instead of what can I do for my son, was the first sign of a new Does, the first time her own person entered the reckoning, and it was from it, from that tiny this is not right thought about herself, that all the rest was born, because a person who begins to think that something is not right for them is a person who has begun, at last, to count themselves.

And she asked herself, for the first time, whether she deserved that, whether a life had to be that, whether she, Does, would not have a right, at least at the end, to a house without fear, to a home where the doorbell was not a threat, to an old age that was not one more crossing of dread.

It cost her, in the days after that night, to look at her son and admit what she felt, because what she felt was a thing a mother does not want to feel: fear, and beneath the fear, shame, and beneath the shame, a touch of a thing resembling anger, and Does had a horror of that anger, because she thought that a

mother cannot have anger at a son, that that was a sin, an unnaturalness. But the anger was there, dull, the anger of one who is treated badly by one they love, the anger of a whole life of giving and being paid with fear, and Dores had to learn, with much difficulty, that that anger did not make her a bad mother, that it was a human and just reaction to an intolerable situation, and that to deny it, to push it down as she had pushed down everything her whole life, only poisoned her more. The anger, she understood slowly, was the part of her that knew that that was not right, that she did not deserve to live with fear at home, that there was a limit there being violated; and instead of condemning it as a sin, perhaps she should hear it as a warning, the warning that she had come to a place where no mother should come and from which she had to get out.

And it was that question, born at the bottom of that night of fear — would I not have a right to a house without fear? —, that began to turn Dores, slowly, from saving toward saving herself, because it was the first time in her life that she put herself into the equation, the first time she thought of her own right to a life without terror, the first time the saviour asked herself whether

she did not need, she too, and before all, to be saved — and that perhaps, that time, the only person who could save her was she herself, by shutting at last a door she had opened her whole life.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Keeper of the Register



It had not been on purpose that Dores had sought the Keeper; it had been because she could no longer bear it alone, and the House of the Register was the only place where she could weep without being pointed at. She went about, since the night of fear, in the state of one who has lost the ground, not knowing whom to turn to, because her problem was not one to complain of to the village, nor to take to the police, nor to bring to the doctor, it was a problem of the heart, that of a mother lost between the love and the fear of a son, and for problems of the heart there is no office nor remedy, there is, at most, someone who listens. And the Keeper was that someone, in Véspera; she gave no remedies nor solutions, she gave what was most lacking, a listening without judgement, a shoulder, an old wisdom about what people carry and about what can and

cannot be saved. And Dores, who had never asked anything of anyone, who prided herself on managing alone, went there, to the House of the Register, and let herself, for the first time in a long while, be heard, be sheltered, be treated as someone who also needs, and that alone, only to be heard without judgement by someone who did not judge her, was already, before any word, a relief, the relief of one who lays down, even if for an hour, a weight they had carried alone for years.

It was to the House of the Register that Dores ended up, in the days after the night of fear, and it was there, with the Keeper, that she heard the words that gave her the courage to do what she had to do, because the Keeper, who kept the memory of the village, had seen many a Dores and many a Quim pass, and knew what remained of each one, and what could, and what could not, be saved.

The House of the Register was, in *Véspera*, the place where the memory of those who had passed through was kept, and the Keeper the woman who tended the books, and there was in the village the idea that people went there to see to papers and came out with another thing, with questions they did not know they carried. Dores was not one to believe much in such things,

but she was so shaken from the night of fear, so without ground, that she went to the House of the Register half because of a paper and half because she needed to be with someone who would not judge her, and the Keeper, who received everyone without judgement, was perhaps the only person in Véspera to whom Dore could say the unsayable, the fear of her son, without feeling it as a betrayal, because the Keeper was not the village, she was the keeper of all, and what one said to her was kept as one keeps a secret in a church.

She had gone to see to a paper, but she went shaken, and the Keeper, who saw deep, perceived it, and asked her how she was, and Dore, who unburdened herself to no one because she had learned not to complain, that time unburdened herself, because the night of fear had broken something within her and she no longer had the strength to keep it. She told everything: the son, the drink, the requests, the always-giving, the debt she had taken on for herself, the fear, the night. And the Keeper listened, without being scandalised, without judging, with the serenity of one who has already heard everything, and when Dore finished, she asked a question no one had asked her: and you, Dore? How long is it since you lived? You have not spoken to

me of yourself a single time. You have spoken to me of your son, as before you will have spoken of your husband. And you, in the midst of all this, where are you?

And Does was left without an answer, because there was not, for years, a Does outside the saving, and the Keeper, seeing the emptiness where an answer ought to be, said a thing Does carried for the rest of her life. She said: hear me well, Does, for this costs but it is the truth. You are not responsible for your son's illness. It was not you who gave it to him, it is not you who cures it, and there is no money nor sacrifice of yours that saves him, because there are things a person can only do for themselves, and to stop drinking is one of them, and that your son has to do alone, or he does not do it. You can love him, you can leave him the door open for when he wants to change, but you cannot save him, Does, however much you kill yourself trying, because to save a man from the drink is not in your hands, it is in his. And while you kill yourself trying to save what you cannot save, you do two bad things: you kill yourself, and you take from him the bottom that perhaps would be the only thing to make him want to save himself. Your love, Does, is serving his illness and killing you. You have to turn it around. You have to learn to love him without saving him.

And do you understand the difference, Does?, the Keeper went on. To love and to save are not the same thing, though you, and so many people, confuse them. You can love your son your whole life, and you should; but to save him, that you cannot, because his salvation is not in your hands. To love is to want his good, is to leave him the door open, is not to strike him from your heart; to save, in the sense in which you do it, is to take from him the consequences, is to carry him, is to do for him what only he can do. The love you can give him forever; the salvation you cannot give him at all. And your mistake, Does, and the mistake of many mothers, was to think that to love you had to save, and that if you stopped saving you stopped loving. No. You can stop saving and go on loving; indeed, only by stopping saving does your love become clean, without the poison of the saving that sinks. Learn to separate the two things, woman, and you will see that your love, freed of the saving, becomes greater and not less.

The Keeper spoke with the serene authority of one who sees the whole village pass through the books and knows, for that, all the fates of the mothers who save. I have seen many like you, Does, she said. I have seen mothers save sons from the drink and from what is worse, and I have seen how it ends. It ends al-

most always in one of two ways: either the mother wears herself out saving and dies before her time, and the son sinks all the same, and the two die; or the mother, in time, sets a limit, and saves herself, and gives the son the only chance he has. I have never seen, in all these books, a mother save a son from the drink by force of giving to him and covering for him; that does not save, woman, that puts off and sinks. The ones who saved anything were those who stopped, those who set the door, those who had the courage to let the son fall so that he might perhaps rise. It is against the instinct, I know; the instinct orders one to grasp, to hold, not to let fall; but with the drink the instinct deceives, because to grasp sinks and to let go perhaps saves. You have to go against your instinct, Does, and that is the hardest thing one asks of a mother, but it is what this situation asks of you. And Does heard, and engraved it, because they were the words of one who had seen many like her pass and knew how the stories ended, and the Keeper was telling her, without circling, that the path she walked had a known end, that of the two sunken, and that there was only one way out, the one that seemed impossible to her, that of letting go to perhaps save.

And the Keeper went to fetch a book, that of the births, and showed Dore's line, written long ago, before the husband, before the son, before everything. Look, she said. Here you are, Dore's, newborn, before you were the saviour of anyone. Look well at this line, Dore's, said the Keeper, with her finger on the line of birth. This girl, when she was born, owed nothing to anyone. She did not have to save her father, nor her husband, nor her son; she did not have to carry anyone; she was born, as everyone is born, with a right to a life of her own, to be cared for, to be happy. And somewhere, far back, someone put on her back a weight that was not hers, that of saving others, and she carried it her whole life thinking it was her duty, thinking it was what she was for. But it was not, Dore's. Look at the line. The line does not say born to save. It says only born. You were born to live, as everyone is, and the saving was a thing they put on your back and that you confused with your nature. Lay it down, woman. You were not born anyone's beast of burden. You were born a person, with a right to a life of your own, and you are still in time to live it, if you lay down what they put on your back and that was never yours to carry.

This girl was not born to let herself be consumed saving men who sink; she was born to live, as everyone, with a right to her own line, to her own life, to her own house without fear. Somewhere along the way they taught you that you were only worth something if you carried others, and you believed it, and you carried, and you are carrying until you die. But it is a lie, Does. You are worth something carrying no one. You have a right to lay down the weight. You have a right to a house without fear. And to set it, that limit, does not make you a bad mother; it makes you a mother who at last understood that she cannot drown to save one who will not let themselves be saved, and that to a son who sinks sometimes what most helps him is not a mother drowned at his side, it is a mother firm on the bank, with the door open for when he wants to swim to her.

There was a moment, in that conversation, when the Keeper touched what was perhaps the deepest, and touched it with care, because she knew it was an old wound. She said: you learned, Does, somewhere, far back, that you only have worth if you save someone, that your place in the world is to carry others, and that is why you do not know how to stop, because to stop saving seems to you to lose your worth, to cease being good for something. But that is a lie, woman, it is a lie they put

into your head as a child and that you have carried for sixty years. You are worth something without saving anyone. You are worth something for being, as everyone is, not for carrying. And while you do not believe this, you are going to look always for someone to save, because without someone to save you feel yourself without worth, and that hunger to feel yourself useful is going to throw you always into the arms of one who sinks, and you are going to drown one time and another proving a worth you already have. Your son does not need you to drown for him; he needs you to stay standing. And you do not need to save him to be worth something; you are already worth something. Learn this, Does, and you are free.

And Does, hearing that, felt a strange thing, a mixture of pain and of relief, because the Keeper had put her finger on a truth she had never formulated but that she recognised the instant she heard it: that she saved to be worth something, that her giving had beneath it a hunger for worth, and that that hunger made her the slave of whoever sank. And to understand this did not cure her at once, but it gave her a key, the key that her problem was not only the son, it was the idea she had of herself, and that to change that idea — to come to believe that she was worth something without saving — was the deep work she had ahead,

deeper even than to shut the door, because to shut the door was the gesture, and to believe that she had a right to shut it, that she was worth something even without saving anyone, was what made the gesture possible.

And Dorel heard that, and it was as though they took off her back a weight of a lifetime, because the Keeper had given her two things she had never had: the absolution — you are not responsible, you cannot cure him, it is not your fault — and the permission — you have a right to a house without fear, you have a right to set a limit, and to set a limit is love and not abandonment. The Keeper, before letting her go, said to her one more thing about doors, that stayed with Dorel and that gave her, perhaps, the image she needed. She said: a door, Dorel, serves for two things: to open and to shut. A door that only opens is not a door, it is a hole in the wall, and through a hole everything enters, the good and the bad, and the house defends itself from nothing. Your door, yours, has gone about open like a hole your whole life, letting in everything they asked of you, and so your house, and you, were left without defence. To learn to shut the door is not to cease being hospitable; it is to make the door a real door, that opens to what is good and shuts to what is bad, that lets in the healthy son and bars the drink. A mother without

a door, who only opens, protects no one, neither the son nor herself; a mother with a real door, who knows when to open and when to shut, that one, yes, has a house that is a refuge and not a hole. And Does kept this image, that of the door that has to know how to shut to be a door, and it was with it in her head that, days later, she at last drew the bolt, understanding that she was not ceasing to be a hospitable mother, she was making her door, for the first time, a real door.

And it was with that absolution and that permission, still trembling but already firm in her breast, that Does left the House of the Register determined to do, at last, what Rosalina had done and what she had always thought impossible: to shut the door — not to her son, but to the drink, to the endless asking, to the fear — and to love Quim, from then on, from a bank where she herself would not drown.

CHAPTER NINE

The bottom



Dores had never been a person to give up, and her difficulty in shutting the door did not come from weakness, it came, paradoxically, from her greatest strength: the stubbornness of one who does not give up on anyone. Her whole life she had been the one who endured, the one who stayed to the end, and that stubbornness, which had been her greatness in raising her children alone and in holding the house in her husband's time, was now her trap, because the same stubbornness that had made her never give up was the one that prevented her from giving up on saving her son. And she was going to have to do, with her greatest strength, a thing that went against her own self: to stop not giving up, which for a woman who had made of not-giving-up her identity was almost like ceasing to be herself.

But between deciding and doing there is a path, and before Does drew the bolt there was still her own bottom, the days when, determined to stop, she discovered how hard it was to stop, and when she almost retreated.

She had left the House of the Register determined, with the Keeper's strength in her breast; but the decision did not hold firm in the days that followed. In the morning, rested, it seemed to her right; at night it seemed to her impossible. And it was on one of those nights, the third or the fourth after the Keeper had spoken to her, that Does nearly yielded for good.

It had been a bad day, with news of Quim arriving by the village's means, that he was worse, that he had got into a serious strait. And at night Does found herself in the kitchen, with the telephone in her hand, dialling half her son's number to tell him that after all she would give, that after all she would open, that after all she could not. She dialled the first numbers, slowly, and stopped, with her heart leaping and her finger over the next digit, and stayed so, suspended, perhaps a minute, perhaps five, with the telephone beeping softly on the other side awaiting the rest of the number. And it was in that minute, suspended between yielding and enduring, that she understood the size of the

prison she lived in: that the fear of a disaster of her son's held her hostage, that that fear would make her give forever. She laid down the telephone. She did not lay it down for good, she laid it on the table, there at hand, and stayed looking at it, and went to fetch a chair and sat down in front of the telephone, as one who keeps watch on an enemy, and spent the rest of the night sitting there, guarding the telephone from herself, and that was the first thing she did alone, at her bottom: to guard herself from her own finger.

The next day, still with the night of the chair in her eyes, she went to Rosalina's house, because she could no longer bear it alone. She knocked, and Rosalina opened, and Does, at the door, without going in, said to her I cannot, Rosalina, I am afraid he will do himself a disaster if I shut the door. How did you manage? And Rosalina pulled her inside, sat her at the table, set a coffee in front of her, and told her the hardest and most freeing truth of the whole story: Does, he can do himself a disaster even if you go on giving, and he can straighten out even if you shut the door, because what he does does not depend on you, it depends on him. His life is not in your hands, it is in his, and that is the hardest thing to accept. You can give him everything and he sink; you can shut the door on him and he save himself;

or the contrary; you do not know, no one knows. What you decide is whether you sink with him or whether you stay alive. Only that is in your hands: your life, not his. And if you shut the door and he, even so, sinks, the fault is not yours, Does, because the illness is his and the choice to treat it is his, and you are not God to save him against his will.

And Does, on the other side of the cup, heard that, and said, with her voice hoarse, but how do I endure it, Rosalina, on the nights? Last night I sat the whole night keeping watch on the telephone so as not to call him. And Rosalina got up, went to the drawer of the dresser, took out a paper and a pencil, and laid them in front of Does, and said, write. Write here the reasons why you are shutting the door, in your own hand, and have this paper at hand, in your apron, on the bedside table, wherever, and on the nights when your heart cries out at you to open, you take out the paper and read it, to remember, with your head, what your heart makes you forget. It is what saved me. I had my paper pinned on the inside of the pantry door, and when I went there, without meaning to, with my hand on the way to the shelf, I came face to face with the paper and stopped. And Does took the pencil, and wrote, slowly, by her own hand, Rosalina dictating nothing to her, only waiting: that to give does not save him,

it sinks him; that in saving him I take from him the bottom that perhaps would save him; that I have a right to a house without fear; that I am not responsible for his illness; that a drowned mother saves no one; that the door is open to the sober son. And she folded the paper in four, and put it in the pocket of her apron, and went away with it, and had it at hand from then on, and read it on the nights of weakness, and it was an anchor to her, a voice of the head holding her when the heart wanted to drag her.

But the reckoning of the head was not enough, and Dores knew it, because the head said one thing and the mother's heart cried out another, and in the moments of distress it was the heart that commanded. And there was, at Dores's bottom, a thing that made it harder to cross: the solitude of the decision. Because the decision to shut the door was hers, hers alone, and no one would be at the door with her on the night she had to keep to it.

It was Glória who eased it for her, without knowing it, on a night when she telephoned. Dores was at the table, with Rosalina's paper open before her, reading it for the umpteenth time, when the telephone rang, and it was her daughter. Mother, said Glória, I know what you are trying to do, Rosalina told me, and I called

only to tell you that I am proud of you, and that you are not alone. And Dores, who had never told her daughter a naked truth in all her life, said to her, softly, I am sitting here with a paper of Rosalina's in front of me, Glória, so as not to go to the telephone and call your brother to tell him I'll give. For an hour I have done nothing but not call. And on the other side there fell a silence different from all the silences there had ever been between the two of them, and then Glória's voice came, changed, hoarse: stay there, Mother, with the paper in front of you, and do not hang up, I'll stay on the telephone with you until the urge passes. And they stayed, mother and daughter, on the telephone, talking of nothing, of the rain, of the grandchildren, of a recipe, and Glória laughed almost weeping, look at the two of us, Mother, years arguing, and after all this was what I wanted, to be on the telephone with you while you do not call Quim. And Dores, that night, at the third bottom of a distress, let herself be held by her daughter, and it was the first time in her life that a woman who had worn herself out saving others let someone save her a little, and it was so strange and so good that she understood how much she had lived without it.

Glória said to her still, before hanging up, already at daybreak, a thing Dorés kept: he gets out of it, Mother, or he does not, but that is no longer in your hands. It is you who never saw him get himself out, because you never gave him time. You always arrived first. And when they hung up, there was already light behind the serra, and the telephone stayed on the table, silent, and Dorés had not called him.

It was not the only night. There were others, and on one of them, of the worst, Dorés did the sums of her life, and the sums shook her. She put herself at the table, with a paper, not Rosalina's, another, and began to add up, more or less, how much she had given Quim over the years. She did not know for certain, no one adds up these things while they give them, but she went on pulling from her memory, a debt here, a rent there, the loan she had taken on for herself, her mother's earrings she had sold, and the number that came out at the bottom of the paper was enormous, was almost all she had had in a lifetime. And alongside, in another column, she tried to add up what all that money had given the son, and the answer was nothing, or worse than nothing, because it had all been to feed what destroyed him. And in a third column, the hardest, she tried to add up what she had given herself in those same years, what she had

spent on herself, on her rest, on a thing of her own, and she was left with the pencil in the air, because there was nothing to add up, the column stayed blank, and to see, so, the column of herself blank beside the column of the son full, was for Dores a balance-sheet of a life, and a bitter balance-sheet, that of a woman who had given everything to one who was not saved and nothing to herself, and who came to the end with empty hands and an empty earring case in a drawer. And it was perhaps that paper of the three columns, cold and clear, more than anything else, that pushed her toward the decision, because it showed her, in numbers, that the path she had walked led nowhere but to the ruin of two, and that it was necessary, at last, to change, if only so that one of them, she, might be saved.

No one saw this combat, because, as always, Dores hid everything. From outside, the village saw a woman who got by, who did her duty, who did not complain; no one imagined her nights, the chair in front of the telephone, Rosalina's paper in her apron, the three columns. And it was Rosalina, once more, who taught her this too: that she did not have to wage it alone, that she could lean on someone. She came to see her, in the late afternoon, with a pretext in her hand, a bunch of cabbages to exchange, a recipe, and she sat down, and drank the coffee, and

kept watch on her friend over the cup for half an hour of no conversation at all, and on the way out, already at the gate, she said only, with no great thing, you are doing well, Does. And that it costs, I know too. If you need company to do nothing, I'll do nothing with you. And she went away, and Does stayed at the gate understanding, slowly, that she had just been sheltered, she, for the first time, and that to receive that, instead of giving it, was in its small way the first time she let someone save her a little, and she began to undo, without noticing it, the oldest knot of all, that of her being only to give and never to receive.

Rosalina's words, his life is not in your hands, it is in his, were the hardest to accept of the whole story, because they went against the deepest feeling of a mother, that of being responsible for the child. A mother feels, to the bone, that the child's life falls to her; and that feeling, just while the child is a child, becomes a trap when the child is an adult who makes their own choices. And Does had to make the hardest crossing of all, that of passing from a mother of a child, responsible for it, to a mother of an adult, whom she loves but does not control, and that crossing, that of letting go of the responsibility for the adult child, goes against thirty, forty years of instinct. But it was the one she had to make, because to go on feeling herself responsi-

ble for the choices of an adult was to condemn herself to an infinite guilt, and was, at bottom, not to acknowledge the son as an adult, not to give him back the dignity of his own life.

And Dores, hearing Rosalina and Glória, understood at last that she carried a responsibility that was not hers, that of her son's fate, and that that impossible responsibility was what crushed her. To let it go, to accept that she was not responsible for his choice, that she could not save him against his will, that she could only save herself, was the hardest and most freeing step of her bottom, because it was to lay down a weight she had carried since girlhood, that of thinking herself responsible for saving everyone. And in laying it down, in the midst of the fear and the pain, with the paper of reasons in the pocket of her apron and the column of herself still to be filled, Dores felt a thing new and light: the possibility of a life that was not to drown saving others, the possibility, at last, of staying alive.

CHAPTER TEN

The bolt



There are small gestures that change a life, and that of drawing a bolt is one of the smallest there is, a gesture of a second, a finger pushing an iron; and it was that tiny gesture, on that night, that changed Dores's life, because gestures are not measured by their size, they are measured by what they carry, and that one carried a whole lifetime. Dores's whole life flowed into that bolt: the girl who had learned to save, the woman who had saved her husband, the mother who saved her son, all of her was in that finger that hesitated over the iron, and to draw the bolt was to go against all of that, against the girl, against the woman, against the mother she had always been, it was a whole lifetime having to yield to a gesture of a second. So that small gesture was so hard; it was not hard for the effort, which it had none, it was hard for the weight, for the whole life-

time it had to overcome to make itself, and Does took longer to decide that finger than she would take to carry a load of stone, because the load of stone is only weight, and that finger was her whole life having to change course.

There was the night when Does shut the door, and it was the hardest and most courageous night of her life, and it was the night that gives the book its name, because it was the night when she drew the bolt on a thing she had opened her whole life, and in doing so saved herself.

Does had prepared for that night, though she did not know when it would come, and she had prepared in the only way she could: deciding, beforehand, what she was going to say and what she was going to do, rehearsing, repeating the words to herself, so that in the moment, with her heart leaping, they would not fail her. Because she knew that in the moment the old instinct would cry out to open, and that if she did not have the words ready, decided coldly, the instinct would win. So she had decided everything beforehand: that she would not open the door if he came in a bad way; that she would speak to him through the door, without opening it, because she was not going to treat him as a stranger but also was not going to expose her-

self; that she would tell him that she loved him and that the door was open to the healthy son and shut to the drink; and that she would draw the bolt. She had decided it coldly, with Rosalina, almost as one rehearses a scene, so that in the heat of the moment she would have a script to cling to, and it was that preparation that saved her, because when the moment came, and her heart raced, and the instinct cried out to open, Dores had the words ready, and clung to them as to a rope, and it was they that held her.

Quim came, as Dores knew he would, with the night ring, the finger on the button, the story, the strait, the request. And Dores, that time, on the other side of the door, with the decision of the House of the Register and Rosalina's strength in her breast, did what she had never done: she did not open. She spoke to him through the door, because she was not going to treat him as a stranger, he was her son, and she told him the truth, with her voice trembling but firm: Quim, I love you, you are my son and you always will be, but this door, this night, does not open. I give you no more money, son, because the money I give you does not save you, it sinks you, and I, in giving it to you, sink with you, and that is over. My house shuts itself to the drink and shuts itself to the asking. But hear me well: to my son, when he comes

sober, when he comes to talk and not to ask, when he wants real help, help to get out of this, that door is always open, by day and by night, and I will do everything. Everything, except go on paying for you to sink. That door I have shut, son. And I draw the bolt.

She heard, from inside, her son react, and it was all she had feared and more. Quim did not accept, of course, because a door that has always opened is not accepted shut suddenly; he insisted, asked, and then, seeing that his mother did not yield, grew angry, and said things, hard things, things a mother does not want to hear from a son, accused her, called her names, threw the blame for everything at her, said that she abandoned him, that what mother was that, that he needed and she shut the door on him. And each word was a knife, and Dores, from inside, with her hand on the bolt, received the knives and did not open, and it was perhaps that the hardest of all, to hear her son accuse her of abandoning him exactly in the moment when she did, for him, the hardest and most loving thing of her life. Because that is the cruelty of this situation: that the son, in his illness, reads the mother's limit as abandonment, and throws the blame at her, and the mother has to bear being accused of unlove precisely when she loves most and best, without being

able to explain, without being understood, alone on the inside with her decision and the son's knives running her through. And Dores endured, repeating to herself that that was not abandonment, that the door was open to the healthy son, that what she shut was to the drink, clinging to that truth against her son's accusations, because if she believed, for an instant, his accusation, if she believed that she was really abandoning him, she would not have endured, she would have opened, she would have yielded, and so she had to cling with all her soul to the truth of what she did, against the reading her son made, so as not to yield.

And she drew the bolt. It was the hardest gesture of her life, to draw that bolt with her son on the other side, to hear him ask, to hear him grow angry, to hear him perhaps weep or threaten or implore, and not to open, to stay on the inside with her hand on the drawn bolt and her heart in pieces, weeping softly, repeating to herself what the Keeper and Rosalina had told her, you are not responsible, you cannot save him, stay alive, the door is open for when he comes sober. It was a night of torture, that of Dores behind the bolt, perhaps the worst of her life, worse than the nights of fear, because on the nights of fear she was a victim and on this one it was she who chose, and to choose to shut the

door to a beloved son is a pain that few pains equal. But Does endured. She did not open. She drew the bolt and kept it drawn, and it was the first time in her life that she set a limit to one she loved, the first time she said no to a son, the first time she chose herself, her house, her life, instead of drowning once more to cushion the fall of another.

The bolt of that door was an old bolt, of iron, of those that are drawn with a dry sound, and Does had never used it, in all the years she had lived there, because the door of her house had never needed a bolt, it had always been a door for opening and not for locking. And it was for that that the gesture had, for her, so much weight: to draw that bolt she had never drawn, to hear that dry sound of the iron shutting, was like sealing a decision, giving it a body, making it real and not only thought. The bolt was the decision made gesture, made iron, made sound, and Does, in drawing it, felt that she did a thing from which there was no going back, that it was no longer an intention she could undo, it was a consummated act, and perhaps it was for that that she needed that physical gesture, the iron, the sound, because a decision only in the head comes apart easily, and she

needed to make it irreversible, to drive it into the world, and the drawn bolt was that, her decision driven into iron, the limit made a thing.

And it must be said, so that it not be misunderstood, what that bolt shut and what it left open, because it was not a shutting of the heart, it was a shutting of the door to a precise thing. Does did not shut the door to her son; she shut it to the drink, to the endless asking, to the saving that killed both. It was important, for Does, to make this clear, and to make it clear to her son too, on that night and on those that followed, because she was afraid that he would understand the bolt as a repudiation, as a ceasing to love him, and it was not that, and she needed him to know it was not that. So she told him, and repeated, through the door and then by other means, that she loved him, that the door was open to the healthy son, that she would do everything for him when he wanted to get out of that; that what was shut was to the drink and to the asking, not to him. She did not know whether he heard her, whether he understood her, whether he believed; probably not, at the time, because the drink does not let one hear those things. But Does said it all the same, time after time, because she needed it to be said, for the son to know, even if he only came to understand much later, that the bolt had never

been against him, it had been against what destroyed him, and that on the inside of that door there had always been, all that time, a mother who loved him and who waited for him.

To her son, to Quim, to the person, she left the door wide open for the day when he came in another way, sober, wanting to change, to accept real help; for that son, said Does, the door would never shut, and she would do everything. The bolt was drawn on the harm, not on the son; on the illness, not on the person; on what destroyed her and sank him, not on the love, which stayed, whole, on the inside, waiting. And that distinction, between shutting the door to the harm and keeping the heart open to the person, was what allowed Does to draw the bolt without feeling it as a betrayal, because she was not abandoning her son, she was refusing to go on taking part in his destruction, which is a very different thing, and which is, at bottom, a higher and harder form of love.

Each second of that night cost her, and it would be a lie to say that Does crossed it serene. She crossed it in pieces, with the bolt drawn and her hand trembling upon it, struggling against the instinct of a whole lifetime that cried out to her to open, to yield, to attend to the son who asked on the other side. Each

sound that came from outside was a knife; each word of Quim's, imploring or full of rage, was a temptation or a stab; and Does had to cling with all her soul to the truth she had learned, to repeat it like a prayer, you are not responsible, you do not save him by drowning, stay alive, the door is open for when he comes sober. It was the hardest thing she did in her life, harder than enduring her husband, harder than raising her children alone, because it was hard against herself, against her deepest instinct as a mother, and each minute with the bolt drawn was a minute of conquering herself, of choosing, against all she was, to save herself instead of saving.

And when, at last, Quim went, or gave up, or the night ended, there came over the house a silence Does did not know: the silence of a door that had stayed shut, the silence of a decision kept, a silence that was at the same time the most painful and the cleanest she had heard in years. Painful, because on the other side of that door went her son, to whom she had just said no for the first time; clean, because it was the first silence in years that was not the silence of waiting nor that of fear, it was the silence of one who has done what they had to do and stayed whole. And Does stayed listening to that silence, sitting on the floor by the door, with her hand still on the bolt, and she went

on letting it in, that new silence, which was the sound of her life beginning again, the sound of a house that became hers again, the sound, however painful, of freedom.

That night, after Quim went, Dores stayed a long time sitting by the shut door, weeping, but it was a weeping different from all the others, it was a weeping of pain and of relief mixed, the pain of having shut the door to a son and the relief of having, at last, stopped drowning. And the next morning, on waking, she had an instant of panic, the panic of one who has done an irreversible thing and is frightened by it: and if he, this night, without my money, did himself a disaster? And if the worst happened, and the fault is mine? And Dores had to cross that morning with her heart in her hand, awaiting news, with the terror that her shutting of the door had had a terrible consequence. And it had not; Quim appeared, days later, alive, angry, asking again, and life went on, and Dores understood that her terror, that of one shutting of the door causing an immediate disaster, was in great part a fantasy of the fear, that the reality was less catastrophic than the fear painted it, that the son did not die from her not giving him money one night, that the sky did not fall. And it was important, that discovery, because the fear of an immediate disaster was one of the things that had bound her to

the always-giving, and to see that the immediate disaster did not happen, that the son went on alive on the far side of the shut bolt, went on taking from her, proof after proof, the power that fear had over her.

And she understood, in that weeping, that she had just done the most loving thing she had done for her son in years, more loving than all the savings: she had given him, with that bolt, the first real consequence of his acts, the first limit, the first firm bank in a sea where he had known only yielding waters. She thought, that night behind the bolt, of Aniceto, and understood that she was doing for her son what she had never managed to do for her husband: to set a limit. To her husband, she had never set one; she had saved him to the end, without ever shutting a door, and he had died all the same, and she had been left with the guilt of not having saved him, without ever understanding that perhaps it was not saving him that he needed, but a limit, an enough, a woman to tell him I do not follow you in this. Too late for Aniceto; but not for Quim, and Dores, in drawing the bolt, did for her son what she had not known how to do for her husband, and it was as though, with that gesture, she not only set a limit to Quim, but repaired, in some way, what she had not done with his father, as though the bolt drawn on that night

shut, at the same time, the door to the son who sank and the cycle of a whole life of saving without limit, a cycle that had begun before the husband, in the house of her childhood, and that she, on that night, with that iron, at last broke.

And she had given herself, with the same gesture, the first night of a new life, a life in which she would no longer drown to save anyone, in which her house would become hers again, in which she, Dores, at last, would choose to live.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

To love from a limit



There is an idea, very widespread, that to love is to have no limits, that true love gives everything, endures everything, forgives everything, and Does had believed that idea her whole life, and it was that idea she had to unlearn after the bolt, because it was that idea that nearly killed her. Love without limits, she understood, is not the highest love; it is, often, the most dangerous, because a love that endures everything ends up enduring the unendurable, and a love that gives everything ends up giving even one's own life, and a love that forgives everything ends up permitting everything. True love, Does learned, has limits, not for being less love, but for being more wise: it knows that there are things that should not be endured, that there are requests that should not be satisfied, that there are behaviours to which one has to say no, precisely out of

love, because to say yes to everything does not help the one we love, it sinks them. And it was hard, for Does, to trade the romantic idea of love without limits for the harder and truer idea of love with limits, because the first is beautiful and the second seems, at first sight, cold; but Does learned, at her own cost, that the beautiful one killed and the cold one saved, and that real love, the one that lasts and the one that helps, is not the one that has no limits, it is the one that knows where to set them.

After the bolt, Does had to learn a new and hard thing, which was to love her son from a limit, to love him without saving him, to keep him in her heart and outside the door of the drink, and she went on learning it, slowly, in that late spring of her life, with relapses and with firmness, because to set a limit once is hard and to keep it is harder still.

To learn to love from a limit was, for Does, like learning a new language when old, with an accent, with mistakes, slowly. Everything in her was trained for the other language, that of giving without limit, and she had to watch herself at every moment so as not to fall into it, so as not to go back to the automatic of saving. It was a constant, conscious, tiring effort, because the instinct always pulled toward the old side, and Does

had to correct it time after time, like one who corrects an accent, and sometimes the accent won and she yielded, and had to begin again. But, as in any language, the practice gave her the knack, and what at first was an enormous and conscious effort went on becoming, slowly, a little more natural, and Dores went on learning to say the no without it costing her her life, to set the limit with less trembling, to distinguish the son from the illness more quickly. It never came to be easy, because these things do not become easy; but it became possible, it became livable, and that was already an immense victory for one who had set out from a total inability to say no.

Because Quim did not give up asking at once, of course. He came back, came back several times, with the stories, with the straits, with the requests, testing the bolt, to see whether his mother yielded as she always had, because a whole lifetime had taught him that his mother always yielded. And Dores had to keep the bolt drawn time after time, had to repeat the no many times, had to endure her son's rage, the guilt he threw at her, the accusations of an unnatural mother, of a mother who abandons her son, and it was very hard, because Quim knew where to touch her, knew the words that wounded her, and threw them at her, and Dores had to endure without yielding, clinging to the

truth she had learned: that to yield was not love, it was sinking, and that her no, however much it hurt the two of them, was more love than her old yes.

The daughter, Glória, on learning that her mother had at last set the limit, came back, and came back in a way that moved Dores: she came back to support her. She telephoned more, came more, told her mother that she was proud of her, that she knew how much it cost, that she was there to hold her on the days when she wavered. And Dores, who in saving Quim had lost Glória a little, recovered her in shutting the door to Quim, because Glória, who could not bear to see her mother sinking, bore well, and even with joy, to see her mother saving herself, and drew near again. And it was an immense relief for Dores, to have her daughter near again, to have someone to support her, because to keep the limit alone was very hard, and to have Glória on her side, holding her on the bad days, reminding her why she did it, was one of the things that allowed her to endure. And there was here a lesson Dores kept: that in saving the son who sank she was losing the daughter who had got free, and that in stopping saving the one who sank she recovered the one who had got free, and that her sacrifice for Quim had had, all

those years, a hidden cost she had never tallied, that of estranging her from Glória, and that that cost, now, in shutting the door, turned into gain.

But at the same time that she kept the bolt shut to the drink, Dores kept, with the same firmness, the door open to her son. She telephoned him, sent word that she loved him, that the door was open for when he wanted to come sober, for when he wanted real help; she never renounced him, never struck him out, never ceased being a mother. The difference, now, is that her love had a new form, a form with a limit: she loved the son, but not the drink; she received the son, but not the request; she had the door open to the person, and the bolt drawn to the harm. Quim, in striking against the shut bolt time after time, went on changing his way of coming, and that was revealing. At first he came with the usual stories and requests, awaiting his mother to yield as always; on seeing that she did not yield, he passed to accusations, to rage, to knives; and then, on seeing that not even the accusations opened the door, he went on drawing away, came less, because a son who came only to ask, on ceasing to get what he asked, ceases to have a reason to come. And there was in this a pain for Dores, that of seeing her son come less, that of understanding that part of what brought

him was the request and that, the request shut, the son became rare; but there was also a clarity, that of seeing, at last, without illusions, what their relationship was, reduced to the request, and that of understanding that a son who came only for the mother to yield was not a relationship, it was an exploitation disguised as a visit, and that the hard truth of seeing him come less was better than the lie of having him there asking. And Does endured this too, to see her son become rare on understanding that the door did not yield, clinging to the hope that, the door of the request shut, perhaps one day the door of the healthy son would open, that of the son who came not to take but to be.

And that form of love, with a limit, was much harder to live than the love without limit of before, because the love without limit was simple, it was to always give, and the love with a limit demanded discernment at every moment, to distinguish the son from the illness, the person from the request, and to keep open one and shut the other, which was a constant and painful exercise, but which was, Does understood, the only love that did not kill her and that perhaps, only perhaps, helped the son.

There were days when she wavered, when she nearly opened the bolt, when the mother's heart nearly defeated the decision. There was a time when she learned that Quim was in a serious strait, bad in earnest, and that everything in her cried out to attend to him, and Dores wept the whole night clinging to the decision, with the telephone in her hand, and did not yield, and it was perhaps the hardest night after that of the bolt, because one thing is not to give when the request is the usual one, another is not to give when one truly fears for the son. And Dores had to learn that the limit is not a victory won once, it is a choice remade every day, and sometimes many times a day, and that each time it costs, and that firmness is not not feeling the temptation to yield, it is feeling it and not yielding. She went on becoming firmer with time, not because it ceased to hurt, but because she went on accumulating the proof that she endured, that the sky did not fall when she did not yield, that she and her son went on alive on the far side of each no, and that proof, accumulated, went on giving her the serenity that the decision alone did not give.

The village, which had seen her always give and had censured her for it, saw her now set the limit and censured her too, because the village always censures, and what before was oh

Dores who always gives to that son became oh Dores who shut the door on her son, poor thing, what a mother. And Dores had to learn to endure this too, the village's censure for the limit, after having endured the censure for the yielding, and she understood a freeing thing: that the village would censure her whatever she did, that there was no way to please the village, that if she gave they censured her and if she did not give they censured her, and that therefore it was not worth governing herself by the village, it was worth governing herself by what was right. And that discovery, that she would never manage to please everyone and that therefore she was free to do what was right without minding what they would say, was one more liberation, because Dores had lived her whole life attentive to what they would say, doing what was expected of a good mother, and to learn to detach herself from what they would say, to do the right thing even censured, was to learn a freedom she had never had, that of one who ceases to live for the approval of others and comes to live for their own conscience.

And there was a change in Dores, as she kept the limit, that the village noticed: she went back to living. She recovered the house, which ceased to be a place of fear, because the bolt drawn to the drink gave her back the safety of the home; she re-

covered her sleep, which came back when she ceased to live in dread of the doorbell; she recovered the little money she had, which ceased to drain into the bottomless well of the requests; and she recovered, slowly, a life of her own, because a woman who stops drowning saving others discovers, suddenly, that she has time, and strength, and even the will, to live. Does, who had worn herself out a whole life saving men who sank, discovered, in the end, with the bolt drawn, the strange lightness of a life that was hers, of days that were not of saving nor of fear, of a house that was at last a refuge and not a stage of distress.

She learned too, in that time, to distinguish what was love from what was fear in her own impulses, and it was a fine learning, because the two disguised themselves as each other. When the impulse came to her to yield, to open the bolt, to give, Does learned to stop and to ask herself: is this love for my son, or is it fear of mine, fear of seeing him suffer, fear of the guilt, fear of losing him? And she discovered, often, that what she took for love was fear, was her own distress wanting relief, and that to yield, in those cases, was not for the good of the son, it was to calm her fear. And she learned that to yield to fear is not to love, it is only to flee the discomfort, and that true love, sometimes, is to endure the discomfort — to endure seeing the son suffer the

consequences, to endure the guilt, to endure the fear — in the name of a good greater than the immediate relief. It was a distinction hard to make in the heat of the moment, with the son at the door and the heart leaping, but Does went on training it, and each time she managed to distinguish the love from the fear and to act out of love and not out of fear, she became a little firmer, a little freer, a little more master of herself.

She thought much, in that time, of Rosalina, and understood that Rosalina, whom the village had called an unnatural mother, had been after all the wisest and most courageous mother she had known, because she had done, before her, what was hardest and most loving: to stop drowning, to set a limit, to love from a bank. There was, in the midst of this learning, a day that was worth many, and it was a day when Quim appeared sober. Not to ask; sober, or almost. He came by day, sober, with a shame-faced air, and stayed at the door without asking anything, and said to his mother some awkward words, that were not a request for money nor a story, they were another thing, they were perhaps the beginning of a thing. And Does, who had the bolt drawn to the drink and to the asking, opened the door wide, because it was exactly this the son to whom the door was always open, the sober son, the son who came to talk and not to ask.

And she received him, and gave him food, and they were, mother and son, a few moments as they had not been in years, with no request in between, with no fear, only a mother and a son at table. It was not a cure, it was not a promise, Quim would sink again perhaps many times still; but it was a glimpse, it was the proof that the bolt drawn to the drink had not shut the son, it had perhaps opened a chink through which, now and then, the sober son could peer, and Does clung to that day, kept it, because it was the living proof that to shut the door to the drink and to open it to the sober son was not a contradiction, it was the most sensible and most loving thing she could do, and that her limit, far from driving the son away, was perhaps what made possible these rare days of a sober son at her table.

And she understood that the village was mistaken in calling love the drowning and unlove the limit, because it was the contrary: the drowning, the always-giving, the saving without end, had as much of fear and of need as of love, and the limit, the bolt, the no that cost, was a higher love, a love that put the true good of the son — the bottom that perhaps would save him — above the immediate relief of the mother in seeing him sheltered. Does had learned, in the end, to love so, in the hard way, and though it

cost her every day, she knew, now, that it was the right way, and that her old love, the one without limit, however well-intentioned, had been a love that killed.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The house given back



It did not all go straight, and it would be a lie to tell it so. There were relapses of Dores, days when she opened the bolt she should have kept shut, when she yielded to a request she should have refused, when the mother's heart defeated the decision. And at each relapse Dores punished herself, thought she had spoiled everything, that she was good for nothing, that she was weak; and it was Rosalina, once more, who taught her the right thing about this too: that a relapse does not spoil everything, that no one does this without relapsing, that what matters is not never to relapse, it is to go back to the limit after relapsing, it is not to make of the relapse a giving-up. You fall, and you get up, and you go back to the bolt, said Rosalina, and the next time you endure a little longer, and so one learns, by stumbling, like everything that is hard. And Dores learned to

treat herself with that gentleness in the relapses, not to make of each yielding a catastrophe, to go back to the limit after breaking it, and it was that gentleness toward herself, that patience with her own relapses, that allowed her, on the whole and despite the stumbles, to keep the course, because one who punishes themselves at each relapse gives up, and one who forgives themselves and tries again, that one, slowly, gets there.

Time passed over the night of the bolt, and when Does looked back she understood that she had recovered a thing she had thought lost forever: her house, and with the house her life, and with the life herself, the Does who had lost herself beneath a whole life of saving men who sank.

It took time, the house becoming a house again, because fears do not go from one day to the next, and Does, even with the bolt drawn, still started many times at a ring, at a step, at the memory of the fear ingrained in her body. But slowly, night after night in which the bolt protected her, day after day in which the house stayed a place of her own, the fear went on settling, went on becoming memory instead of present, and the house went on becoming what it had been. Does relearned to be in her house without alarm, to sit at the window without her ear listening, to

open the door without her heart leaping, because now it was she who decided who entered, it was she who had the bolt, and to have the bolt, to be able to shut it, gave her back the mastery of her own house that the fear had taken from her. And there was a day when Does understood that she no longer had fear in her house, that the house had become a refuge again and not a stage of distress, and it was a day of a deep and simple joy, that of a woman who recovered her home, which is one of the most basic and most precious things there is, the right to feel safe between one's own walls, a right that the fear had robbed her of and that the bolt had given her back.

The house, first. The house that had been a home and had become a place of fear became a home again, because the bolt drawn to the door gave it back its safety. Does ceased to dread the doorbell, ceased to live on alert, ceased to hide the money and to lock the things, because the door shut to the harm had made of the house, again, a refuge. And she relearned to dwell in her house with pleasure, to sit at the window without a start, to sleep at night without her ear listening for the dreaded ring, to receive whom she wanted to receive, the neighbours, Rosalina, people who came for the company and not for the request. The house, given back, became what it had been before

the crossings of fear, and Does, in dwelling in it in peace, felt a deep gratitude for that simple quiet, that of a woman safe in her house, which she had not had in years and which she had thought never to have again.

The sleep, before the life. Because the first thing that came back, after the bolt, was the sleep, and Does understood, in recovering it, how much she had lost it. For years she had slept badly, with a light and startled sleep, always listening for the doorbell, always awaiting the night ring, and when the drawn bolt took from her the fear of the doorbell, the sleep came back, slowly, and with the sleep there came back a thing Does had forgotten existed: rest. To wake in the morning rested, without the weight of a night of vigil, was such a great novelty that Does almost wept the first time it happened to her, because she understood, by contrast, how much she had lived exhausted, how much the fear had robbed her of, for years, even of sleep. And the body, with the sleep back, went on remaking itself: Does recovered a little of the weight she had lost, of the colour, of the strength, because a body that sleeps and that ceases to live in alarm remakes itself, and Does's remade itself, slowly, and the village noticed, oh Does has a better look about her, and she had, be-

cause a woman who recovers her sleep and her peace recovers her face, and Does's face, which had gone about a shadow, became again that of a living person.

The life, afterward. With the house given back and the money that ceased to drain and the strength that ceased to be spent on savings, Does discovered that she had, at last, a life to live, and she went on living it, slowly, in the manner of one who relearns a thing they had forgotten. She went back to caring for herself, which she had abandoned; she went back to having her small joys, her days, her people; she went back to being a woman and not only a worn saviour. And there was a strangeness in this, and a guilt, at first, the guilt of living well while her son sank; but Does learned, with Rosalina and with the Keeper, that her life did not have to stop because her son's had stopped, that to drown with him did not save him, that she had a right to live even if he chose not to live, and that to live, she, was even the only good thing she could still offer her son: the example of a person who chose life, and the open door of a living mother for when he, one day, wanted to choose it too.

There was a thing Does did not expect and that the new life brought her: the guilt, which she feared would pursue her forever after shutting the door, went on transforming itself, slowly, into another thing. At first, the guilt was enormous — the guilt of having shut the door to a son, of having let him fall, of living well while he sank —, and there were days when the guilt nearly made her retreat, nearly made her run to open the bolt. But with time, and with the help of Rosalina and the Keeper, Does went on understanding that the guilt she felt was not the guilt of having done wrong, it was the guilt of having done a new thing, a thing against the habit of a lifetime, and that those two guilts resemble each other but are different: one is the voice of conscience telling us we err, the other is only the discomfort of changing, the protest of an old habit at being crossed. And Does's guilt was of the second kind, it was the habit of saving protesting at having been crossed, and not the conscience accusing her of an error, because, thinking it through, she had done no wrong: she had protected herself, set a limit, left the door open to the sober son. There was no error there, only novelty, and the guilt went on dissolving as the novelty became habit, as Does went on convincing herself that she had the right to do what she had done.

And there were, at last, moments of peace, that Dores had not known in years. An afternoon sewing at the window without a start. A night of whole sleep without her ear listening for the doorbell. A Sunday with Rosalina and others, laughing, living. Small things, but that for Dores were enormous, because they were the proof that life, even with the son still sunk, even with the uncertainty of his outcome, could have peace, could have joy, could be lived. And Dores clung to those peaces, not with guilt, but with gratitude, because she had learned that to have a right to her own peace was not to betray her son, it was the only solid base from which she could still love him and, if one day he came sober, could still help him — because a drowned mother helps no one, and a mother on her feet, with her house firm and her heart open, that one, yes, is ready for the day when the son, perhaps, wants to come back.

And Quim? Quim is the part this story does not close, because life does not close these stories, and it would be a lie to tell it in another way. Quim was not cured by magic when his mother drew the bolt; no one is cured so, and the drink is a deep and stubborn illness that does not go with a mother's limit. What happened was truer and more uncertain: Quim, without his mother's money cushioning his falls, began to feel the conse-

quences of his acts, to touch bottoms that the mother had put off for him, and that was hard, very hard, for him and for Dores who watched him from afar; but it was, perhaps, the only thing that gave him a chance, because it is from the bottoms that the will to climb is sometimes born. Whether Quim would climb, Dores did not know, no one knew, and she had to learn to live with that uncertainty, to love her son without a guarantee of outcome, to keep the door open without knowing whether he would cross it sober one day. But she knew one thing: that while she had saved him, the son had had no chance at all to change, because he never reached the bottom; and that now, with the bolt drawn, he had at least that, the chance to touch the bottom and perhaps want to climb. The mother's limit did not guarantee the son's salvation; but it was, perhaps, the only thing that made it possible.

Dores became, with time, a voice for other mothers of the village in the same strait, as Rosalina had been for her. When she learned of a mother sinking to save a son who was destroying himself, she drew near to her, with the authority of one who had made the crossing, and told her what they had told her: that she was not responsible for her son's illness, that she did not cure it by sacrificing herself, that to drown with him did not save either

of the two, that to set a limit was love and not abandonment. And some heard her, and others did not, as she herself at first had not heard Rosalina; but Does said it all the same, because she knew the price of not hearing, and because to transform her pain into a warning for others was the way to give meaning to all she had been through, to make of her crossing of fear a light for those who came behind. And there was a silent community of these women, in *Véspera*, those who had learned to love from a limit, and they held one another on the hard nights, and Does, who had worn herself out a lifetime in the solitude of one who saves, found in the end the company of those who share the same combat, and that company was one of the best things of her new life.

And there was, on one of those days of the new life, a visit from Glória, with the grandchildren, and it was a visit such as Does had not had in years, a real family visit, with the house full of good people, without fear, without request, only the joy of being together. And Does, watching the grandchildren play in the house that had become a home again, watching her daughter at peace, felt a happiness she had thought lost forever, and understood that in shutting the door to the son who sank she had not shut the door to life, she had opened it; that the house, free of

the fear, could receive joy again; that there was still, in her life, much to live and to love, the grandchildren, the daughter, the friends, herself. And she understood that if she had gone on drowning with Quim she would have lost this too, this joy, these grandchildren, this daughter, this full house, because a drowned woman receives no joy at all, and that in saving herself she had also saved her capacity to live all the rest, all the good that life still gave her and that the drowning with her son would have robbed her of.

And one night, already in that new life, Dores made the gesture that became hers, and said aloud what she had learned, for herself and for the house given back:

The door of my house shuts itself to the drink, and to the asking, and to the fear; to my son, when he comes sober, it is always open, and I will do everything. But I die no more to save him. I love him from a bank, with the door open and the bolt at hand, and I stay alive, because my life counts too, because I too have a right to a house without fear, because a drowned mother saves no one, and the best thing I can be, for myself and for him, is a living mother, firm on the bank, with my heart open and my feet on the ground.

And there came, with time, a peace Dores did not know, and that was not the peace of one who has resolved everything — because nothing was resolved, the son went on sunk, the future went on uncertain —, it was the peace of one who has done what they had to do, of one who has put their part in order and handed over to the son his part, of one who has ceased to carry what was not theirs. It is a strange peace, that, that of accepting that one cannot save the one we love, that of laying down the weight of a responsibility that was not ours, and Dores learned that it is not a peace of giving-up nor of coldness, it is a peace of truth, that of one who has accepted the limits of their power and stopped torturing themselves trying the impossible. She went on loving Quim, went on suffering for him, went on wishing that he would save himself; but she no longer carried his salvation on her back as though it were hers to achieve, and that difference, between loving and wishing the good of the son and carrying the responsibility of saving him, was all the difference between a tortured life and a life at peace, and Dores, in making it, found, in the midst of a situation that went on painful, a peace that the situation had not changed but that she, in changing her way of carrying it, had won.

And she drew the bolt, that night, not with the pain of the first time, but with the serenity of one who had learned, at last, that to shut the door to the harm is the way to keep the house, and the life, and the heart, open to what is good — and that that, and not the drowning, is the love that lasts.

From the register of Véspera

The Keeper of this time says that there was a mother, in Véspera, who wore herself out a lifetime saving those who sank and who only at the end learned to shut the door to the harm without shutting the heart to the person.

Dores, widow of Aniceto, mother of Joaquim. She saved her husband, who drank, and then her son, who inherited his father's thirst, and she covered, paid, endured, always gave, until she was afraid of her own son in her own house, and until she discovered that her love without limit sank the two of them. It took a night of fear, and a Keeper, and a neighbour who had already made the crossing, for her to understand what no one had taught her: that she was not responsible for her son's illness, that she did not cure it by sacrificing herself, and that to drown saving him saved neither of the two.

And it was recorded, so that it be set down and console whoever reads it, that in shutting the door to the son who sank Dores recovered the daughter who had drawn away, Glória, who could not bear to see her mother consume herself and who came back when she saw her save herself; and that she became, in the village, a voice for other mothers in the same strait, telling them what they had told her; and that she found again the company of others who had made the same crossing, and that in that company she ceased to carry alone what she had carried her whole life.

It was recorded that she drew the bolt — not on her son, but on the drink, on the endless asking, on the fear; and that she left the door open to the son who would come sober, for when he wanted it. That she recovered the house, the sleep, the life, and herself. And that she learned to love from a bank, firm on the ground, with her heart open and her feet steady, instead of drowning again. The son's outcome stayed in the son's hands, as it had to stay; what changed, and what was in her hands, was that Does chose, at last, to stay alive.

And it is set down, for whoever reads and recognises themselves, that this is not a story against a mother's love, it is a story in favour of it: in favour of a love that does not destroy itself, that knows how to set a limit, that distinguishes saving from sinking, that loves without drowning. It does not condemn the mother who gives; it understands her, because to give comes from love; but it shows her that there is a love greater than always giving, and that that love, the one that knows how to shut the door to the harm and keep it open to the person, is harder and truer. And it does not condemn the son who sinks, who deserves compassion and not contempt, because his is an illness and not a wickedness; it shows only that there are things that not even the greatest mother's love can do for a son, and that one of them is to save him from himself, because that salvation, if it comes, will have to come from him.

The register says who was born, who married whom, who departed. It does not say what it costs a mother to set a limit to a son she loves, nor that to shut the door to the harm can be more love than all the open doors. There are those who drown saving those who sink, without seeing that to stay on

the bank saves more than to dive in. For those, books such as this one are needed. And of all of it a record was made.



For the reader

Thank you for crossing these nights of Véspera with
Dores.

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